

The Deconstruction of Faith

*Why People Are Leaving the Church — and What Comes
After*

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INTRODUCTION

The Exodus Nobody Wanted

Consider the woman who gave fifteen years to youth ministry. She led worship and taught Bible studies. She went on three mission trips to places where the electricity cut out every afternoon. She led other people's children to Jesus, and she prayed with her own children every night from the moment they could form words. At thirty-eight she wrote her pastor a letter explaining why she was done — and her pastor, a good man, could not find in it the thing he had missed.

What he had missed was not in the letter. The letter named the abuse scandals. It named the way the church voted on the election the year her grandmother died. It named the third miscarriage and the women who told her God must have a plan. Two pages long, every paragraph a true thing. But none of it was the thing.

The thing was that she had spent fifteen years being told about a God she had come to suspect was not the God

She is not rare. The people leaving the American church are not, for the most part, people who never loved Jesus. They are people who loved him enough to notice when he was replaced with something easier to market. This is not a defense of American Christianity, which in its most common expressions does not deserve one. Neither is it a celebration of leaving. Most of what people find when they leave is colder, thinner, and lonelier than they were told it would be. The honest account is harder: the thing they walked away from and the thing they went looking for are both, in many cases, distortions. There is a third thing. It is older than the brand they left and stranger than the freedom they were promised. The pages that follow are an invitation to go find it.

FOUR READERS, ONE ROOM

This book is written toward four people at once. The first is the deconstructor who has not landed anywhere. You read the books. You listened to the podcasts. You cried in your car after the service one Sunday and did not go back. You are not a villain in a church newsletter. You are a person who noticed something, and what you noticed deserves to be taken seriously. It also deserves some things nobody in the deconstruction pipeline is telling you, because most of that pipeline runs on a business model that depends on you staying lost.

The second is the pastor watching his people leave with nothing to say. You have tried the apologetics. You have tried more Jesus-centered preaching, small groups,

The third is the parent whose adult child has stopped coming home for Easter. You blame yourself, the college, the boyfriend or the girlfriend or the internet. You pray every day and you do not know what to say when your child calls. This book wants to give you something to say. More than that, it wants to give you something to stop saying.

The fourth is the faithful church member who has not deconstructed and cannot imagine why anyone would. You love your church and your pastor. You read your Bible, you see what it says, and you trust it. Nothing here is written to shake you. It is written so that when your neighbor or your niece or your coworker begins to wobble, you will recognize what is actually happening, and you will not make it worse by defending a version of Christianity the Bible never taught.

THE SCALE OF THE THING

What is being described here is not anecdotal. Pew Research has tracked it for two decades. The share of Americans who identify as Christian has fallen from roughly eighty percent at the turn of the century to somewhere near sixty-five percent today, and the decline is accelerating rather than leveling. Among adults under thirty, the numbers are worse. The fastest-growing religious category in the United States is none. Not atheist. Not agnostic. None.

*The arguments are not the problem.
The institution is the problem. The
church created most of what it now
refuses to recognize.*

Precision is owed on one more point. The word deconstruction, as the popular conversation uses it, means different things to different people. For some it means the total rejection of the Christian faith. For some it means the rejection of one tradition within that faith, with the possibility of landing in another. For some it is a season of questioning that may or may not end in departure. For some it is the slow erosion of convictions that were never deeply held. For some it is the traumatic

WHAT THIS BOOK IS NOT

It is not a list of answers to objections. The apologetics industry has produced enough of those to fill a library, and most deconstructors have already read them. The books did not fail because the arguments were bad. They failed because the question underneath the question was never the one the books were answering.

Neither is it a soft Christianity with the edges sanded off. The faith is not flexible in its essentials. Jesus rose from the dead or he did not. He is Lord or he is not. Scripture is true or it is not. There is no third option on those claims, and pretending otherwise is a failure of love. What is flexible is the cultural packaging Americans have wrapped around the essentials until packaging and thing became indistinguishable in the average pew. The packaging is not the faith. Telling the difference is most of this book's work.

No writer who pretends to have no skin in this should be trusted, and the writer of these pages does not pretend. He came to faith from atheism, in a small group of college students who answered his questions rather than deflecting them. He has been a pastor for more than a decade in a small Michigan town. He has doubted. He has watched people he loved walk away. He has said things from the pulpit he would not say now, and held positions

If you are in one of those rooms, the offer is to sit across from you for the length of this book and say some true things clearly. You do not have to agree with all of them. You only have to take them seriously. That is the contract.

A word on order. The book is written in a sequence, but the reader need not follow it. A parent whose child has left should start with the chapter on parents. A pastor trying to figure out what to preach should start with doubt, or with hell. A deconstructor who wants to know whether reconstruction is possible should start there. Anyone angry at the church and wondering whether this book sees what they see should start with spiritual abuse. The book is built to be entered from many doors. Each chapter assumes you have not read the others. The argument builds across the whole, but each piece can stand alone, and it is better to read the chapter you need than to read in sequence and give up before you reach it.

There is no chapter here that did not need to be written, and none written without cost. The subject does not permit distance. The aim throughout has been to close the distance — between the page and the reader, between the pastor and the person who no longer trusts him, between the institution and the human being it failed. Whether the aim has been met is for the reader to decide. The minimum the subject demanded was the attempt. Turn the page.

CHAPTER ONE

What Deconstruction Actually Is

The word has been ruined. That is where we have to begin. Fifteen years ago deconstruction belonged to literary theory and the occasional theology seminar, and almost nobody outside a graduate room used it at all. Five years ago it surfaced in Instagram bios and podcast titles. Today it functions less as a description than as a flag. To the right of that flag stand the people who want you to know they are done with the American church; to the left stand the people who want you to know they are not. The flag has come loose from the thing it was meant to describe.

If we are going to get anywhere useful, we need the word back. It will be used here in a specific sense. Deconstruction is the process of examining the beliefs you inherited to determine which are actually load-bearing, which are cultural accretion, and which are simply wrong. It is, in other words, what every serious Christian is supposed to do. The Bereans received the message with



Now the Bereans were of more noble character than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if what Paul said was true.

– ACTS 17:11

Paul commended them for it. Luke put the story in the Bible. A church that does not continuously examine its own teaching against Scripture is not being faithful. It is being lazy. That is the honest version of the word.

What most people mean when they say deconstruction today is narrower and more combustible. They mean a specific crisis of trust that a specific generation of American Christians is having with a specific version of American Christianity. The crisis is real. The word was dragged into the culture war and beaten half to death on the way. We can still use it. We only have to be precise about what we mean.

A WORKING DEFINITION

Deconstruction, as most people are using the word, is the experience of discovering a gap between the Christianity you were taught and the Christianity you find in Scripture and history, and not knowing what to do with the gap. It is not the same thing as deconversion. It is not the same thing as liberalism. It is not the same thing as rebellion. It is a particular kind of painful awakening that can end in several different places, and where it ends depends enormously on who is standing in the room and what they are saying.

Deconstruction is the examination. It is what the word actually means, a disassembly that may or may not end in a rebuild. Some deconstruction ends in a stronger faith, some in a different faith, some in no faith. The disassembly itself is neutral. A faith that cannot survive honest examination was not going to survive anyway.

Deconversion is the conclusion that the faith is not true. It is not a process. It is a landing. A person can deconstruct without deconverting, and a person can deconstruct and then deconvert. But deconversion is a destination. Deconstruction is the road.

Renovation is the name for the healthy version. It is what happens when a believer discovers that the house they were living in had structural problems, tears out the bad framing, and rebuilds on the original foundation. The foundation is Christ. The framing was the cultural assumptions they had mistaken for Christ. The house at the end of a renovation looks different from the house at the beginning. The ground underneath is the same.

These three words matter because churches keep treating deconstruction as if it were deconversion, and deconstructors keep treating deconversion as if it were renovation. Both are category errors. Both cost people who did not have to be lost.

THE TWO MISREADINGS

Consider the pastor — and there are many — who has a young woman in his church begin to ask hard questions. She is reading widely. She is bringing him material he

At the moment of the warning she was not a deconverter. She was not even a renovator yet. She was a first-year deconstructor with her hand on the examination tools, doing the work the Bereans did. The pastor misread the phase. His misreading cost the church a member. It may yet cost more.

The opposite error is more common in the podcast ecosystem. A Christian begins to ask hard questions, finds a community of other people asking hard questions, and is told, explicitly or by the shape of the conversation, that the questions themselves are the point. That doubt is a virtue. That certainty is the enemy. That the faithful response to a hard question is to keep the question open forever. This is not deconstruction. It is a permanent scaffolding around a house that never gets rebuilt. The scaffolding becomes its own house. The house of scaffolding has no roof, and winter comes for everyone.

THREE KINDS OF DECONSTRUCTOR

If the response a person needs depends on what kind of

The Berean is doing the work Paul commended. This person is testing what they were taught against Scripture, reading primary sources, and is often more biblically literate than the leaders worried about them. They do not need to be warned. They need a pastor who can keep up with them. If their church cannot keep up, they will find a church that can, or they will find a library that can, and the library does not come with accountability.

The Wounded was hurt by the church. This person was told purity was the measure of their worth and has now spent a decade disentangling their sexuality from their shame. They were in a youth group where the leader turned out to be a predator. They were in a family where the pastor defended the abuser. They were in a tradition that voted a particular way in a particular election and told them from the pulpit that voting any other way was sin, and when they watched the consequences of that vote unfold they watched the pulpit defend those consequences, and they could not do it anymore. The Wounded do not, in most cases, have a theological problem. They have an integrity problem. They watched the institution violate what it said it believed. They need to meet a version of the church that does not do that. Apologetics will not help them. Repentance will.

The Drift has gotten bored. Church went from a thing that made sense of their life to a thing that happened on Sunday mornings. The questions they are asking are not really questions. They are reasons, scaffolding for a decision that was made six months ago in their stomach.

The categories are not rigid. A person can be a wounded Berean. A Drift can become a wounded renovator after enough therapy. They are diagnostic tools, not cages. The point is that the response a person needs depends on which category they are in, and the American church's default move is to treat every deconstructor as a Drift who needs to be corralled or a Wounded person who needs to be told to forgive. The Berean gets treated like a Drift and leaves because nobody took them seriously. The Wounded gets treated like a Drift and leaves because nobody took their pain seriously. The Drift gets treated like a Berean, handed apologetics, and leaves because nobody saw what was actually going on.

A cardiologist who treats every chest pain as reflux will eventually kill someone. A church that treats every deconstructor the same way is killing something too. It is killing its own future.

One more thing, before we move to what they are actually leaving. Deconstruction is not primarily an intellectual event. That is the mistake the apologetics industry keeps making. It treats deconstruction as a debate, and the debate can be won with better arguments. But by the time most people are in deconstruction, the arguments have stopped doing the work they were designed to do. Not because the arguments are weak. Because arguments do not repair trust, and the thing that has broken is trust.

When a child discovers that a parent lied about one important thing, the child does not begin with the question of whether the parent is correct on other matters. The child begins with the question of what else the parent lied about. The child may still love the parent. The child may still live in the house. But the child is in a different relationship now. The parent cannot repair it by providing a list of other things they did not lie about. The parent has to acknowledge the lie, own it, and let the child see what it costs to tell the truth. The relationship, if it rebuilds, rebuilds on something deeper than before. But it rebuilds slowly.

The American church told its children some things about Jesus, about Scripture, about holiness, about power, that do not hold up to examination. Some of what we told them is true and good and will outlast every critic. Some of what we told them was cultural sediment we had mistaken for gospel. The children are old enough now to tell the difference. They are asking us to tell them which is which. A church that cannot answer that question is not going to keep its children, and a church that answers it defensively is going to keep fewer.

CHAPTER TWO

What They Are Really Leaving

Most deconstruction is not about Jesus. It is about the package Jesus was sold inside. Anyone who wants to understand why people are walking out has to look hard at the package, because the package is what they are leaving.

A pastor's first instinct, when someone he loves begins to deconstruct, is to defend the essentials. He says the resurrection is true. He says the Bible is true. He says Jesus is Lord. He is not wrong about any of it. But he is answering questions the deconstructor has not yet asked. The deconstructor is not, in most cases, standing in front of him to debate the resurrection. The deconstructor is standing in front of him to ask whether the church that teaches the resurrection has become something Jesus himself would not recognize.

That is a different conversation. And the pastor who answers the first question while the second one is being asked will watch the deconstructor leave, wondering why

THE PURITY CULTURE CATASTROPHE

A generation of Christians, mostly but not only young women, were taught from the pulpit and the small group that their worth before God and before any future spouse was measured by whether they had kissed anyone, held a hand past a certain line, or thought about anyone in a way that crossed some unmarked threshold. They were told they were rose petals, that every touch was a petal lost, and that by the wedding there would be nothing left for the groom if they had not guarded the petals. They were told the way they dressed was a direct cause of other people's sin. They were handed rings and pledges at thirteen and told the ring made them holy.

Then they grew up. Some reached marriage beds and could not function, because their bodies had learned to associate desire with disgust. Some divorced, because the men they married, raised on the same material, could not function either. Some walked out of a marriage to a youth pastor who had groomed them at sixteen and found their church blaming them for the groom. They read the Song of Songs in their thirties and realized the church had taught them the opposite of what Scripture actually says about the body. They looked at the ring. They looked at the scars. They left.

THE SEXUAL ABUSE SCANDALS

They kept coming. Catholic first, then evangelical, then denomination after denomination. The Houston Chronicle

A generation watched this happen in slow motion and asked the question no one wants spoken aloud. If the institution is this willing to protect itself at the cost of the vulnerable, why assume it is telling the truth about God? That is the corrosive question. It is not a question about God. It is a question about the institution's reliability as a witness. And a witness whose reliability has collapsed cannot restore it by shouting louder about the message. It can only restore it by telling the truth about itself and paying the cost. Most institutions will not pay the cost. So they lose the witness.

THE POLITICAL CAPTIVITY OF THE AMERICAN CHURCH

This is the one pastors hate most, which is reason to be careful with it and no reason to be soft. There is a version of American Christianity that has become indistinguishable from a political tribe. It has a preferred party, a preferred leader, and a preferred set of enemies. It baptizes those preferences with language from the pulpit. It implies, and sometimes says openly, that a Christian who votes differently is not really a Christian. It meets

Pastors vote. They hold opinions about policy they could defend with Scripture and reason. The point is not that Christians should have no political views. The point is sharper than that. When an entire generation of young people watched their parents' church endorse, defend, and excuse conduct from a politician that the same church would have disciplined a deacon for, they learned something. They learned that the church's professed ethics were not real ethics. They were tribal markers. The ethics bent when the tribe needed them to bend. A young person raised to take the sermons seriously will not take them seriously again once they have seen this. They may keep attending for a while. They will not believe the sermons.

When politics becomes the lens through which Scripture is read, Scripture stops functioning as Scripture. The tribe, not the risen Christ, becomes the actual authority.

This is not a left-wing point. There are progressive versions of the same captivity, churches that have let their politics rewrite their theology exactly as thoroughly as

THE PROSPERITY GOSPEL AND ITS SOFTER COUSINS

The hard version is obvious. Seed your faith, plant your money, claim your healing, buy the pastor a jet. Most readers already see through it. The softer cousins are more dangerous because they are more plausible. They appear as preaching that treats Jesus mainly as a resource for a better life. They surface in worship songs that sing of God as a romantic partner whose job is to reassure. They take the form of the ministry that measures success by attendance and giving rather than by cruciformity. They come through as the assumption, pervasive and mostly unconscious, that faith is supposed to make life work. When life does not work, the faith feels broken. When enough life does not work, the faith feels like a lie.

Many of the people walking out have hit a wall their faith was never built to contain. A miscarriage. A divorce they did not want. A child with a diagnosis. A cancer that does not respond. They turned to a faith they were told would work and discovered that the version they were given has no theology for the wall. The New Testament does. Paul wrote Philippians from prison, and the theme of the letter is joy. James opened his letter to believers with a hard command:

Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds.

Job sat on the ash heap, refused to curse God, and was declared righteous. The Christian faith carries an enormous theology of suffering. The American church has mostly traded it for a theology of breakthrough. The wall meets the breakthrough theology and the breakthrough theology shatters. The person concludes that Christianity has failed. What has failed is a sub-Christian substitute.

THE DOMESTICATION OF JESUS

This one is quieter, and it runs underneath the others. At some point the Jesus who flipped the tables in the temple, called the religious experts whitewashed tombs, stood before a hostile crowd and named their hypocrisy, wept over the city that had killed its prophets, and went willingly to a Roman cross at the hands of the cooperative religious establishment of his day became, in the American imagination, a friendly spiritual life coach who mostly wants people to be nice. The Sermon on the Mount was reread as personal wisdom rather than kingdom ethics. The parables were flattened into moral stories rather than kingdom subversions. The miracles were reinterpreted as personal demonstrations rather than signs of a new world breaking in. The resurrection was treated as a ticket to heaven rather than the beginning of a new creation.

The result is a Jesus who fits in the living room. He threatens no one. He asks nothing that costs the middle class anything. He never stands on the side of the poor in a way that would embarrass a donor. He can be endorsed by a candidate, printed on a coffee mug, and quoted on the back of a merchandise tee. He is not the Jesus of the

BIBLICAL ILLITERACY DRESSED AS BIBLICAL FAITHFULNESS

A movement that loves the Bible and does not read it is a movement in trouble. Across the American church, from the pew to the pulpit, the Bible is cited constantly and engaged rarely. A person can attend an evangelical church for twenty years and never have worked through a single book of it slowly, in context, with the flow of the argument intact. They hear verses. They do not read books. They memorize proof-texts for positions. They do not sit inside the text long enough for it to reshape the positions.

The young people asking the hard questions have, in many cases, started reading the Bible for themselves. They have discovered that what the book actually says is stranger, stronger, and more disruptive than what the church taught them it said. They have discovered that the proof-texts were often ripped out of contexts that say nearly the opposite. They have discovered that the verses they were told were obvious are, read slowly, deeply contested. They have discovered, in short, that the people who told them the Bible clearly says this or that had not read the surrounding chapters recently, or had never read them at all, and were repeating a tradition dressed as exegesis. This is catastrophic. It means the church lost its authority the moment the reader caught up. And the readers have caught up.

And then there is the thing that turns deconstructing believers into departing ones more than any other item on

For the Berean and the Wounded alike, this is the final signal. The institution cannot self-correct. It has tied its identity to its own infallibility. A person cannot grow inside an institution that cannot be wrong. So they leave.

That is the list, and it does not deserve softening. All of it is real. All of it is happening. A church that wants to respond has to begin by admitting that the critique is not coming primarily from faithlessness. It is coming from the uncomfortable fact that, on most of these items, the critics have read the Bible more carefully than the institution they are critiquing. That is hard to accept. Accepting it is where any honest response has to start.

No pastor gets to stand above this list, and the honest ones know it. Over fifteen years many have defended from the pulpit positions they would not defend now, and answered a deconstructor's question with a defensiveness that was about protecting the institution rather than shepherding the soul. To name the list is to confess a share in it. Nobody in American ministry is exempt.

To the deconstructor reading this: at least some pastors are aware the list is real and are trying to do something about it. To the pastor reading this: welcome to the discomfort. The next chapter is about why the church keeps missing what is actually being said, and how to stop.

CHAPTER THREE

Why the Church Keeps Missing It

There is a particular conversation that happens between a pastor and someone deconstructing their faith, and any pastor who has lasted has been in it. The deconstructor says something honest. The pastor hears something threatening. The pastor answers the thing he heard, and the deconstructor hears a man who did not hear them. So they say it again, louder, and the pastor, still hearing threat, answers with more force. The deconstructor leaves. The pastor tells the elders the person was never really open to correction. The elders nod. The next deconstructor walks in and the cycle begins again.

The miss keeps happening, and it can be stopped. What follows is aimed at pastors, but anyone who loves someone in this place needs it, because the parents of deconstructing adult children make the same mistakes, usually for the same reasons. The mistakes are not about stupidity. They are about reflex. The reflex is the thing to

THE DEFENSIVE CROUCH AND THE TRIBAL SLOT

The first reflex is to defend. When someone criticizes the church, a pastor's trained response, honed over a decade of culture-war formation, is to explain why the criticism is not fair. That is sometimes the right move. It is almost never the first one. What the deconstructor offers, in many cases, is not a debate but a grief. They are grieving the loss of a simpler faith, the discovery that something they trusted was not trustworthy. A pastor who rushes to defend the institution has refused to grieve with them. That refusal is a choice, and the person reading it reads it correctly: a pastor who cannot grieve is a pastor standing with the institution and not with the sheep.

The pastoral move is to grieve first. The defense, if warranted, can come later, in another conversation, after trust has been rebuilt. The grief cannot be skipped. When Jesus stood over Jerusalem and wept, he was not defending the temple. He was mourning the city. A pastor who cannot mourn the American church cannot be trusted to speak truthfully about it.

The second reflex is to file the deconstructor under an enemy tribe. The critic who names political captivity is a liberal. The one wounded by purity culture is a progressive. The one grieving the abuse scandals has been listening to the wrong podcasts. Each move takes the concrete pain standing in the room and turns it into a slot in the culture war. Once it is in the slot, the pastor knows what to do with it. The culture war has scripts. The scripts are easier than the person.

The discipline is to listen long enough to discover that the one in front of you is not the caricature in your head. It takes more than the five minutes at the coffee table after the service. Schedule the coffee. Drink it slowly. Ask three follow-up questions before saying anything declarative. A shepherd who will not look at a sheep long enough to recognize it is not shepherding anything.

ANSWERING THE QUESTION THAT WAS NOT ASKED

The third reflex belongs to apologetics. The pastor is trained to have answers, so when a question comes, he produces one, aimed at the question the apologetics textbook anticipated. But the textbook was written for the skeptic in the debate room. The deconstructor is not in the debate room. They are in an existential crisis that occasionally takes the shape of a question resembling something from one.

So the question sounds like this: are the Gospels historically reliable? The pastor has the answer. He talks about the early manuscripts, the multiple independent attestations, the criterion of embarrassment. All of it is

*The question underneath the question
is rarely the one the textbook
anticipated. The humility to ask what
it is, not the knowledge to answer what
it isn't, is the discipline.*

Learn to ask what lies underneath. The way to find out is usually to ask, directly. What are you most afraid of in this? What would it mean if the thing you fear were true? What made you ask it now? The questions are not complicated. The humility to ask them is.

THE SOLUTION SERMON AND THE SLIPPERY-SLOPE PANIC

The fourth reflex is the urge to fix. The pastor reaches for the sermon he would preach with thirty minutes and delivers a compressed version at the coffee table, certain

A compressed sermon at the coffee table is the pastoral equivalent of handing a grieving widow a pamphlet on the stages of grief. The information may be accurate. It is the wrong thing in that moment. What she needs is someone to sit down and not talk for a minute. The deconstructor needs the same: a person who can be present without needing to produce something. Presence comes before solution. The order matters.

The test is simple. Can you hold a thirty-minute conversation with a deconstructor in which you tell them nothing? You only ask. You reflect back what they said. You acknowledge what is true. You stay with what is hard. At the end, they should feel more heard than in any previous conversation on the subject in their life. Fail that test and they will not come back, and the fault is yours.

The fifth reflex is fear. The pastor watches a person begin to ask serious questions and projects forward to the worst version of where those questions might lead. Once the worst case is in his head, every conversation is with the worst case and not the person. He warns them away from books they have already read. He implies their direction ends in apostasy. He mentions, in a tone meant to be gentle and failing, that he has seen this go badly before.

The person hears, accurately, that the pastor is afraid of them, and once they hear the fear they know this is not a man they can be honest with. So they begin to protect him from their real questions. They hand him the sanitized

The discipline is to stay in the room with the worst version of the question. When a person says, I am not sure I believe the resurrection anymore, the answer is, tell me more, said without flinching. It requires believing, deep in the bones, that the resurrection is strong enough to survive being examined out loud. Where that belief is missing, the problem is not the deconstructor. The problem is the pastor's own faith, and it must be repaired before he tries to repair anyone else's.

WHEN THE COMMUNITY TREATS DOUBT AS CONTAGION

The sixth reflex is the hardest to admit, because it is so often done and so rarely named. When a person's deconstruction becomes public, or merely known, the community treats them as contagious. Other members are warned to be careful around them. Small group goes stilted. The deconstructor notices. They always notice. They experience it as social exile, because that is what it is. They leave, and the leaving gets attributed to their unbelief, when in truth it was catalyzed by a community that treated questions as a threat to be contained rather than a soul to be carried.

The early church had a different posture. Thomas doubted the resurrection in public. A week later Jesus



Put your finger here; see my hands. Reach out your hand and put it into my side. Stop doubting and believe.

— JOHN 20:27

Jesus did not shame Thomas. He did not exile him. He did not warn the other disciples about him. He gave Thomas access to the evidence and trusted the evidence to do its work. Thomas came through. If Jesus could bear Thomas, a small group can bear the young mother with hard questions.

It is hard because it costs something. It costs the pastor his certainty that he is automatically in the right. It costs the community its sense that its boundaries are clean. It costs the institution the comfort of never examining itself. Every one of those costs is worth paying, because the alternative is losing people who did not have to be lost.

THE DISCIPLINE OF SHUTTING UP

Consider the conversation as it can go when the reflexes are set aside. A woman comes to her pastor to say she is done. She has a list of reasons. Some he agrees with, some he does not. He has spent the week preparing a careful response in case she asks for one — arguments ready, verses ready, a pastoral plan.

She sits down and tells him her reasons, and in the middle of them she starts to cry. Not performatively. Not strategically. She cries the way a person cries when they have held something for a long time and finally let it go. The pastoral question, in that moment, is whether the plan

Sometimes she comes back. Not right away. Months later, in a different seat than she used to take, reading the Bible more carefully than the pastor does, her questions sharper than before, her faith stronger than it has ever been. None of that is the pastor's doing. What he did, in the right moment, was shut up. Had he obeyed his first three reflexes, he would have lost her.

Most deconstruction conversations will not go that well. Some people will leave and not come back. That is not the pastor's fault, and he should not carry it as if it were. The rest of this book gets inside what they have been reading, what they have been finding, and what faithfulness looks like when it is not wearing the costume.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Bible the Critics Found

There is a version of the Bible handed out in Sunday school. There is a version atheists describe on YouTube. Neither is quite the Bible. The actual book is stranger, older, and more disruptive than either party wants to admit, and a person in deconstruction, picking it up honestly, is in a fair fight with it for the first time. That fight is where this chapter lives.

What follows walks through the hardest places the critics have found and tells the truth about each one. Some of their points are good, and the church has not answered them well. Some dissolve the moment one stops reading the Bible with the assumptions of a twenty-first-century American and starts reading it with the assumptions of the people who wrote it. Either way, the reading has to be done. There is no shortcut. The good news, which will not feel like good news until one is on the other side, is that the Bible can take the pressure. What has failed the tests is not

THE MANUSCRIPTS AND THE CANON

The critic says the Bible has been copied so many times that no one knows what it originally said. This is the version that fills a sixteen-year-old's feed, and it feels devastating. On closer inspection it is the weakest argument in the skeptic's arsenal.

The New Testament is, by orders of magnitude, the best-attested document of the ancient world: earlier manuscripts, more manuscripts, and more geographically distributed manuscripts than any comparable ancient text. Where there are variants, and there are many, the overwhelming majority are spelling differences, word-order changes, and scribal adjustments that do not touch meaning. The places where a variant actually bears on doctrine can be counted on two hands, and even there the doctrine is defended from dozens of other texts. The manuscript argument is a bogeyman. A sixty-minute honest look at the data ends it.

The Old Testament tells a more interesting story. The Dead Sea Scrolls revealed a Hebrew Bible text that was, with minor variation, the same one in use now, a thousand years older than the previous copies. A stunning vindication of textual stability. But the Scrolls also showed different textual traditions coexisting in the same period, with slightly different readings, and that reality is represented in English Bibles for anyone who reads the footnotes. The footnotes are the argument. The text is transparent about its own history. To a person trained to expect the Bible to hide, that transparency is the first surprise of honest engagement.

What the church did with the canon is what a family does with photographs. Not every picture taken of a grandmother goes in the album. The ones that go in are the ones the family recognizes. The ones that do not are not suppressed. They are simply not claimed. The authoritative claim is communal and retrospective, made by the people who know the face.

THE VIOLENCE

This one is harder. The critic points at the conquest of Canaan and asks how a loving God could command the slaughter of entire populations. The easy answers taught in youth group will not hold.

It will not do to say the Canaanites were all wicked and deserved it, because the text includes infants. It will not do

Here is what a careful reading shows. The conquest narratives are written in the language of the ancient Near East, where hyperbole in war reporting is a standard literary convention. A king would say he utterly destroyed a city and then, three chapters later, describe capturing the same city again. The ancient reader knew the convention and knew how to read it. The modern reader, untrained in the genre, reads it flat and recoils. The texts are also clear that the Canaanites had been given time to repent. Genesis tells Abraham the iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete, and will not be for four hundred years. The judgment was not arbitrary. It was the end of a long patience.

 *The iniquity of the Amorites is not yet complete.*

— GENESIS 15:16

And the very standard that brings judgment on the Canaanites brings judgment on Israel a few centuries later, when Israel becomes Canaanite in its behavior. The God of the Old Testament is not a tribal deity who favors his people and smites everyone else. He is the moral judge of all nations, beginning with his own.

None of this removes the difficulty. The text is hard. It is supposed to be hard. But the critic who treats the violence passages as proof that the biblical God is a monster has not wrestled with the text; he has skimmed it looking for ammunition. The reader who has worked through Walter Moberly or Paul Copan or Greg Boyd, even where they disagree on the details, knows there is a

*What has failed the tests is not the text.
It is the packaging.*

THE CONTRADICTIONS AND THE AUTHORSHIP QUESTIONS

The critic lists alleged contradictions. The Gospels give different numbers of angels at the tomb. The crucifixion accounts seem to place the event on different days. Paul's Damascus-road story is told three times in Acts with different details.

Each is either an apparent discrepancy that dissolves on closer reading or a real variation that reflects the character of eyewitness testimony. Real witnesses of real events do not give identical accounts. They give overlapping, differently angled accounts that agree on the load-bearing facts and differ on the rest. Four videos of the same car accident do not match frame for frame. They do show the same accident. The Gospels, read as what they are, function as four overlapping testimonies to the same life. The differences are marks of credibility, not forgery. Forgers align details. Witnesses do not.

The authorship questions follow the same shape. The critic says Moses did not write the Pentateuch, that the

The critic has, in many cases, accepted the most skeptical version of critical scholarship as if it were settled fact, when the actual situation is far more contested. A reader who has worked through Richard Bauckham on eyewitness testimony knows the other side is not being represented. Bauckham is not fringe. He is Cambridge. The one-sided reading the critic inherited is itself a form of indoctrination.

THE HARD TEXTS AND THE LOAD-BEARING GREEK

On sexuality and gender many deconstructors are most concerned, and here the honest answer is narrow. The texts say what they say. The historic church read them the way it did because that is what they say.

The revisionist readings, charitable as some are, require theological moves that, applied consistently, dissolve the authority of Scripture itself, because the

One example shows how a single Greek word can change the argument, standing in for a dozen the deconstructor will meet. The word *metanoia* is usually translated repentance, and most people hear repentance and think of guilt, contrition, groveling. The word does not mean that. It is a compound. *Meta* is a preposition meaning after, or across, or with. *Noia* comes from *nous*, mind. *Metanoia* means something like a change of mind across time, a reorientation of the whole thinking self. Etymologically it has nothing to do with feeling bad.

Jesus did not stand by the Jordan and tell people to feel worse. He told them the kingdom of God was at hand and their minds needed to rearrange. That is a different gospel call than much American preaching has delivered. A deconstructor told that Christian faith is about feeling adequately guilty meets a different faith when meeting the actual word: a faith that asks for a reorientation of the whole mental architecture. That is harder than feeling bad. It is also far more freeing.

THE FAITHFUL RESPONSE

There is more. There is always more. The point is not to produce an apologetic tract that answers every question. The point is to name what is true.

The faithful response to the Bible the critics found is not defense. It is deeper reading. The Bereans did not defend Paul. They examined what Paul said against Scripture, and the church is asked to do the same with its inheritance. If the inheritance survives the examination, it survives stronger. If parts of it are sediment rather than gold, let them go. The gold is heavier anyway.

The Jesus under the brand is the next thing to find. He has been under there the whole time.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Jesus Who Was Buried Under the Brand

Read the Gospels for a month. Only the Gospels, and no commentary beside them, no sermon in the ear. Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, straight through, slowly, as though the story were new. At the end of the month the question is simple: is the man in those four books the same man preached most Sundays of one's life? For most American Christians who have run the experiment honestly, the answer is no.

The Jesus of the Gospels is not rude for its own sake, but he is not smooth either. He is confrontational with the religious professionals and tender with prostitutes and tax collectors. He breaks the Sabbath protocols the experts of his day treated as load-bearing. He eats with the wrong people on purpose, and often. He answers a trap question with a question of his own. He tells stories that end where

He is not the Jesus on the coffee mug.

The gentleness is not the error. Jesus did welcome children. He did feed the crowds. He did forgive sinners, and the tenderness in him is real, not invented. The error is amputation. The American church did not manufacture the gentle Jesus; it cut everything else away and kept the gentleness as the whole. A Jesus who is only gentle is a Jesus no one would trouble to crucify. The cross requires a man who threatened powerful people with something real, real enough that they decided he had to die. That man is not on the mug. He was edited out.

THE JESUS THE BRAND COULD NOT SELL

John 6 is among the most telling chapters in the Gospels. Jesus feeds the five thousand. The crowd ignites and moves to make him king by force. He withdraws. The next day, when they track him down, he preaches a sermon engineered to thin them out. They must eat his flesh and drink his blood, he says, and the text records the result without softening it:

After this many of his disciples turned back and no longer walked with him.

— JOHN 6:66

This is not a marketing strategy. It is not a megachurch

Then there is the Jesus who indicts the religious establishment. Read Matthew 23 aloud, and listen to the rhythm of it. Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites — seven times. You shut the kingdom of heaven in people's faces. You cross sea and land to make one convert, and make him twice the child of hell you are. You tithe mint and dill and cumin and have left undone the weightier matters of the law, justice and mercy and faithfulness. You are whitewashed tombs, beautiful outside and full of dead men's bones within.

This is the Jesus the domestication has removed. He would not fit easily behind the pulpit of many churches that wear his name. To most of them he would be the guest speaker the elder board gently advises against inviting back.

And there is the Jesus who stands with the margins. He touches lepers, which the law said would defile him, and instead of defiling him the touch heals them. He talks with a Samaritan woman at a well in the open day, which no respectable rabbi would have done. He receives a woman caught in adultery, refuses to let her accusers stone her, and tells her to go and sin no more. Both halves are him. The mercy and the moral clarity are not in tension. They are the same love speaking in two directions at once.

The American church has tended to keep one half and discard the other. The progressive version keeps the mercy and drops the moral clarity. The conservative

THE PARABLES WERE LANDMINES

The parable of the prodigal son is not chiefly about the prodigal. It is about the older brother. The punchline is not the party; it is the father leaving the party to plead with the son who stayed home and resented everyone who came back. Jesus told that story to Pharisees, not to prodigals. The domesticated reading has the Pharisees cheering the welcome of the younger son, when the parable is aimed straight at their chest. They are the older brother. He is telling them they are the ones who will not come in.

Read as they were delivered, to the audiences who first heard them, most of the parables are not cozy moral tales. They are kingdom landmines. The good Samaritan is told to a lawyer who wanted to know who counted as his neighbor, and the answer is that the ethnic enemy is the neighbor, and the one who refuses to act on it is no better than the priest and the Levite who walked past. The workers in the vineyard is a story about grace that offends the laborers who came first, because grace does offend the long-faithful the moment they see that the latecomer receives exactly what they received.

*Undomesticated, each parable is a
trap set for a particular hearer — and*

Domesticated, each becomes a vague lesson about being kind. That is the cost of the edit. The story built to detonate under the religious is repackaged as a greeting card for the comfortable.

THE JESUS WHO CRIES

John 11. The shortest verse in the English Bible. Lazarus is dead, and Jesus, who knows he is about to raise him, does not skip the grief:

| *Jesus wept.*

— JOHN 11:35

The tears are not a performance, not practice grief. They are the grief of God at a world that contains a word like dead. Jesus weeps because his friend is dead, because his friends are broken, because death itself is an enemy he hates and is about to fight — and he will win this round and lose the next and win the one after that for everyone who has ever lived. The tears are real. They are not subordinated to the miracle. The miracle is not what makes the tears valid; the tears are valid because grief is valid, and God himself is saying so.

This is not the Jesus who tells the bereaved to count their blessings. This is the Jesus who weeps with a couple over a miscarriage, holds a hand through chemotherapy,

THE JESUS WHO DIES ON PURPOSE

The crucifixion, in the Gospels, is not an accident. It is not something that merely happened to Jesus. He walks into the trap with his eyes open:

When the days drew near for him to be taken up, he set his face to go to Jerusalem.

— LUKE 9:51

He tells the disciples in advance what is coming. He prays at Gethsemane not to escape the cross but for the strength to bear it. He goes silent before Pilate, because there is nothing left to say to a man already convicted by his own cowardice. Then he dies, slowly, in public, for the people who had cheered his death days earlier, for people not yet born, for people reading this page.

The atonement is not a transaction between Jesus and an angry Father who needed blood. That caricature has done enormous damage. The atonement is Jesus, God in the flesh, absorbing into himself the full weight of what has gone wrong between God and human beings and bearing it until it breaks — the triune God doing in himself what no human being could do. It is the love of God arriving at the worst address in human history, the cross, and refusing to leave until the worst thing has been defeated. It is not a trick or a loophole. It is what the whole Bible has pointed at

THE JESUS WHO ROSE

The resurrection is the hinge of everything. Without it, the Christian faith is a touching ethical tradition with an inspiring founder, no more binding than any other. With it, everything else follows. The earliest Christians did not announce the resurrection as a metaphor. They announced it as a historical claim — that they had eaten fish with him — and they died for it. Not for the ethics. Not for the community. For the claim that a particular man had walked out of a particular tomb on a particular morning, and that they had seen him.

The deconstructor has to do something with the resurrection. He can deny it, in which case Christianity is false and all the labor of reforming it is wasted, because what is not true cannot be reformed. He can accept it, in which case everything else stands downstream of that morning, and a church that abuses or misreads the implications is still accountable to the man who walked out of the tomb. There is no third door where the resurrection is vaguely inspiring but not historical while the rest of the faith carries on as a culturally valuable tradition. Paul shut that door:

If Christ has not been raised, our preaching is useless and so is your faith. More than that, we are then found to be false witnesses about God.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 15:14-15

Paul did not believe the faith could survive without the

WHAT IS UNDER THE PAINT

Here is the thing to carry out of this chapter. The Jesus of the Gospels is worth following, and in American Christianity he has been painted over by a Jesus easier to market. To lose faith in the marketed Jesus may be exactly the loss that frees a person to find the other one.

A deconstruction that strips the paint and reveals the original wood is not a loss of faith. It is a restoration. What lies under the paint is stranger and stronger than anyone was told. The Jesus who wept at Lazarus's tomb, drove out the moneychangers, ate with Matthew, and walked toward Jerusalem with his face set is a person worth loving, even now, at the end of a long disillusionment. He is not nervous about anyone's doubts. He has seen worse.

The next chapter is about the history that was never taught. The church has done terrible things and faithful things, and the faithful version of Christian history is stronger than the sanitized one its critics assume is being hidden.

CHAPTER SIX

The History the Youth Group Did Not Teach

Most American Christians received church history in pieces, in high school or college, usually in the mouth of a critic. The story runs the same way every time. The church invented itself at Nicaea as a political instrument of Rome. It burned witches. It ran the Inquisition. It blessed the crusades. It defended slavery. It fought science at every turn. It did some charity along the way, mostly as cover for the rest. And here we are.

That version is not nothing. Each item in it carries some truth at its core. The problem is that it is the scandal reel of two thousand years told as though it were the whole film. A church lived every single day of those two millennia, and most of what happened in those days never made the reel. The footage is accurate. It is also a sliver. The person who watches only the scandal reel believes he has seen the movie. He has not.

The honest history is not a defense. The sins are real

That is not an argument that Christianity is true. It is an argument for being fair to the record. The record includes the crusades. It also includes the hospitals. No one gets one without the other.

THE EARLY CHURCH

Start here, because this is the period the critic imagines as either a purer time the later church betrayed or a mess the later church invented. Neither is true.

For its first three centuries, before it held any political power, the church was a mostly urban, mostly poor, mostly mixed movement of Jews and Gentiles. They met in houses. They shared food across social boundaries the Roman world found scandalous. They nursed the plague-sick when everyone else fled the cities. They refused to expose unwanted infants in a culture that did so routinely. They raised the standing of women, slaves, and children by slow insistence on the image of God in every human being. They were martyred for refusing to worship the

THE IMPERIAL CHURCH

When Constantine converted and Christianity became first a permitted and then a privileged religion, something shifted, and the shift has fed centuries of argument.

Some of it was good. The persecution stopped. The church could build in the open. The emperor could be held to account by ecclesial voices, at least in theory, in a way no one had managed before. When Ambrose stood up to Theodosius, a moral weight entered the world that had not existed in it. Some of it was disastrous. The church took up the instruments of the state. It began to coerce belief. It started measuring itself by size and influence rather than by the shape of the cross. The Constantinian shift, as historians name it, is not one thing. It is a long entanglement whose costs and gains are still being counted.

The honest believer need not defend every imperial move. Augustine made arguments for coercing the Donatists that most Christians today rightly reject. That does not mean Augustine is discarded. It means he was a man writing inside a particular political moment, and one can honor his best work while refusing his worst. Every great thinker demands that kind of reading. The critic who treats each historical Christian failure as proof the

THE MEDIEVAL PERIOD

The period the critic raises most often is the one he knows least. Yes, there were crusades. They were not a single event.

The crusades were a complicated, multi-century series of military campaigns driven by a mix of motives — some genuinely religious, some political, some economic, some plainly sinful. Some were defensive answers to real aggression. Some were offensive, and a few of those committed atrocities that contemporary Christians condemned at the time. When crusaders sacked Constantinople in 1204, turning on fellow Christians, the papacy denounced it. The full story is uglier in places than the critic knows and more complicated in others than the defender admits.

The same medieval church built the universities that eventually produced the scientists the critic celebrates. It preserved the classical texts through the collapse of Rome. It produced Thomas Aquinas, whose holding-together of faith and reason has not been bettered in eight hundred years. It produced Francis of Assisi, whose poverty and gentleness shaped the moral imagination of a continent. It produced hospitals, the first theories of international law, the first serious accounts of a just war, and the monasteries where women could read, write, and govern

THE REFORMATION

This one runs closer to home, because most American Christians, whether they know it or not, are its heirs.

The Reformation was not simple. It was a multi-generational fracturing of the Western church, driven by genuine theological renewal, real ecclesial corruption, the rise of national politics, a new communications technology in the printing press, and several strong personalities who did not much like one another. Luther's convictions about justification by grace through faith recovered something long obscured, and the recovery has given life to half a billion believers. Luther's later writings on the Jews were a moral catastrophe that fed real evil down the centuries. Both are Luther.

The wars of religion that followed killed a great many people. They also clarified, eventually, that coercion in matters of conscience was a road the church could not keep walking. The principle of religious freedom, which the secular critic usually credits to the Enlightenment, was hammered out in large part by Christians sickened by what happened when Christians tried to force one another's consciences. Roger Williams founded Rhode Island as a project of religious liberty. William Penn did the same with Pennsylvania. These were Christian works, grounded in Christian conviction, that became the ground for the secular critic's freedom to object.

THE QUESTION OF SLAVERY

That defense was no minor footnote. It was a large, sophisticated, well-resourced theological project, with seminary professors and denominational statements and pamphlets distributed by the thousands. It was wrong. It was a spectacular failure of exegesis in service of an economic and cultural interest the exegetes refused to examine. The abolitionists, many of them also Christians, read the same Bible and reached the opposite conclusion, and they were right.

That the wrong side lost the argument does not erase the damage. Black Americans whose ancestors were enslaved owe no gratitude that the abolitionists eventually prevailed. The church's part in slavery is a wound the American church has still not fully reckoned with. The deconstructor leaving over the race question is seeing a real failure. The right answer is not to point at Wilberforce and call it settled. The right answer is to examine, repent, and make restitution in whatever forms the situation requires. The church has begun this in some places. It has a long way to go.

But here is what the critic misses. The framework that finally defeated slavery was itself a Christian framework. The claim that every human being bears the image of God, that there is neither slave nor free in Christ, that the poor are blessed and the meek will inherit the earth — that was the crowbar. The abolitionists were not stepping outside Christianity to oppose slavery. They were stepping further inside it than the slaveholders had dared. The slaveholders had the surface. The abolitionists had the core.

THE CIVIL RIGHTS MOVEMENT

The movement that dismantled American legal segregation was, at its center, a Christian movement.

Martin Luther King, Jr. was not a secular humanist borrowing religious language for effect. He was a Baptist minister whose theology was the engine of his ethics. The Southern Christian Leadership Conference was Southern and Christian and led by ministers. The marchers sang church hymns. The strategy was nonviolent resistance rooted in the Sermon on the Mount and the suffering servant of Isaiah. The moral authority that moved a nation came from the tradition the critic now dismisses as past saving.

Both things are true at once. The American church, in aggregate, was disgracefully silent or actively complicit through the civil rights era, and King wrote his letter from the Birmingham jail in part to rebuke the white pastors who counseled patience. The same American church, through particular men and women and particular congregations, produced the movement that forced the

That pattern — a church called back to itself by its own best voices — is the shape of the honest story. It is how slavery was ended. It is how segregation was dismantled. It is how the medieval church reformed itself more than once. It is how the early church held together through persecution. A tradition capable of self-correction is a living tradition. A tradition that only ever defends itself is dead.

The American church is now being asked to self-correct on several fronts at once. Abuse. Political captivity. Racial reckoning. Gender and power. Biblical illiteracy. Many of the deconstructors are the voices calling it back to itself. Not all of them are right. Not all of their proposals are wise. But the posture — the willingness to name the failure in public and ask for better — is exactly what has, historically, kept the tradition alive. Scripture has always made room for that voice:



*Let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness
like an ever-flowing stream.*

— AMOS 5:24

A church that listens to its own prophets, even when the prophets are angry, is a church with a future. A church that only hunts its prophets down will not have one. The path through the questions begins there — not around them, but through. What rebuilt faith looks like, what it does not look like, and why those who have reached it call the cost worth paying, is the work of what comes next.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Path Through

There is no program for this. The terrain can be described; the road cannot be paved in advance, because it has to be walked. What can be set down is the difference between those who came out the other side with a stronger faith than they carried in and those who got stuck — and that difference is not a formula. It is closer to the habits of good travelers, who arrive by different routes, at different paces, with different temperaments, and share a few disciplines. The disciplines are what can be taught.

READ THE SOURCES, AND STAY WITH WHAT HURTS

The first discipline is to stop reading about the argument and start reading the argument. If the question is whether the Gospels are reliable, read the Gospels. If the question is what Paul actually said about women, read his letters entire, in a good translation, with a notebook open. If the question is what Augustine thought, read Augustine. If it is what the Reformers taught about grace, read the

No seminary degree is required, only a Bible, a few introductory books by careful scholars on either side of the questions that matter, and the humility to stay with the text rather than skim it. Most who deconstruct discover, after three months of actual reading, that the critics and the defenders they had trusted were both working with sloppy versions of the sources. The primary texts are almost always more interesting, more complicated, and more persuasive than the summaries handed down secondhand.

The second discipline follows from the first: refuse to look away from the parts of the Bible that are difficult. When a passage unsettles, the temptation runs in two directions: dismiss it as proof the whole book is broken, or explain it away until it stops bothering. Both are evasions. The right move is to stay in front of the passage. Read it slowly. Read it alongside commentators who disagree with each other. Ask what it would have meant to its first readers, and what it still means. Let the difficulty be difficult.

The binding of Isaac, the conquest narratives, the imprecatory psalms, Paul on the women of Corinth — none of these resolve in an afternoon. Careful readers have worked some of them for two thousand years and the conversation is still live. The task is not to resolve them. The task is to stay in the conversation. A faith that cannot live with unresolved questions is a faith that has not yet met the Bible. The Bible is not a comfort blanket. It is a text that wrestles its reader, as the angel wrestled Jacob, and

FIND THE SAINTS WHO WRESTLED

The third discipline is to find out who in the history of the church asked these questions first, and to read them. This may be the most consoling discovery available to anyone in the middle of deconstruction. Whatever the trial, someone has been through it. Someone has written about it. Someone has come out the other side with faith intact and left a map.

For the grieving and the angry, there are the Psalms — a full curriculum in holy complaint, more than a third of them laments. Psalm 88, the darkest poem in the book, ends in unresolved darkness; God placed that psalm in the songbook on purpose. Grief is in the Bible. Anger at God is in the Bible. It is not a sign of having left the faith. It is a sign of having finally entered it.

For doubt there is Augustine's Confessions, and Dostoevsky, and the Cloud of Unknowing. There is Julian of Norwich, who watched a plague kill a third of her neighbors and wrote that all shall be well, and all shall be well, and all manner of thing shall be well — not as a platitude but as a costly claim she had earned. There is Bonhoeffer, writing from a Nazi prison. There is Lewis, writing through the death of his wife. There is Habakkuk, who stood on his watchtower and demanded that God answer him and received an answer he was still working out when the book ran out of pages.

O Lord, how long shall I cry for help, and you will not hear?

None of these were weaklings. They were saints, and some of them died for the faith after the wrestling was done. To stand in that company is to be carried for a little while. The favor gets returned someday, for someone the wrestler will never meet.

REFUSE THE BINARY

The fourth discipline is to refuse the false choice that the apologetics industry and the deconstruction industry both insist upon. The one says that if every doubt cannot be resolved, the faith is broken. The other says that if every doubt cannot be resolved, the faith is a lie. Both are wrong. The faith is not a deductive proof. It is a relationship with a person who rose from the dead, held within a community, tested against the witness of the Scriptures and the history of the tradition. A relationship can carry unresolved questions. A living faith always has them.

What is being asked is not certainty. It is commitment in the direction of the truth that has been seen — and trust that the person at the center of the faith is sturdy enough to hold a doubt without punishing it.

Thomas was not rebuked. He was offered wounds to

STAY IN A LOCAL BODY

The fifth discipline is the hardest for many, and it is to stay embedded in an actual church through the whole of it. Not, necessarily, the church where the wounding happened — that may not be possible. But a church. A small group. A community of believers who know a name and will pray for the one who cannot pray that week.

The deconstruction pipeline on social media is a solitary practice engineered to keep its subjects isolated. The algorithm feeds more content, more angry voices, more confirmation, until it feels like community when it is only a feed. A feed cannot hold a hand when a mother dies. It will not bring a casserole when a child is in the hospital. It will not notice a disappearance. A local church, at its best, is still the place where the body of Christ shows up in bread and wine and actual bodies. The bodies are necessary. No faith grows in a feed.

Churches that can bear hard questions exist, though not always obviously. Often they are smaller than the one that did the harm, less polished, led by pastors who are tired rather than triumphant. Sit in the back a while. Tell one person the story. If they can hold it, stay. If they cannot, try somewhere else. Do not abandon the body because the body disappointed. The body is the means of grace in the New Testament, the way Christ keeps showing up. Without it comes the attempt to manufacture what only the body can give, and the manufacture fails.

The sixth discipline is the strangest and the most reliable. Keep praying. Keep reading. Keep showing up. Even when belief is in doubt — especially then. The old monastic tradition called this a discipline of the body that eventually catches up with the heart. The practice comes before the feeling of the practice. Over time, the practice shapes the self performing it. An atheist who began kneeling in prayer out of intellectual curiosity would not, a year later, be the same atheist. That is not manipulation. That is how bodies work.

| *Prayer doesn't change God. It changes me.*

— ATTRIBUTED TO C. S. LEWIS

Lewis held that prayer is not a mechanism for changing God but a means of becoming the kind of person for whom certain things are possible. The same holds for every Christian practice — communion, confession, singing, reading the Scriptures aloud, giving, serving, sabbath. None of them require certainty. All of them form a self that becomes, over time, more able to see what is actually there. Belief is not the price of admission to the practices. The practices are how belief is built, and usually in that order.

LET THE REBUILD DIFFER FROM THE ORIGINAL

The seventh discipline is a kind of permission. Faith after deconstruction will not look the same as faith before. That is not a tragedy. It is the point. A renovated house is not the house it used to be. It is a better house on the same foundation, the load-bearing walls exposed and repaired.

The outcome may be more theologically settled on some questions and less politically committed on others — more attached to the local church and less to the celebrity culture of the platform, more confident about the essentials and less about the accretions. Whatever it turns out to be, it will belong to the one who wrestled for it. Not a parent's faith. Not a youth pastor's. Not a favorite podcaster's. One's own, fought for and kept. The people of Hebrews 11 had a faith like that.

It is not quick. Anyone who claims to have come out the other side in six months is either lying or still going. A real renovation takes years, sometimes a decade. There is no falling behind, because there is no schedule.

It is not painless. There will be grief and anger, nights of believing none of it and mornings when the grief lands in a grocery aisle and forces a retreat to the parking lot. This is the ordinary shape of loss and reformation happening at once.

It is not without witnesses.



Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us run with endurance the race that is set before us.

— HEBREWS 12:1

They went before and they are not gone. The cloud cannot be seen, but it can be felt — in the songs that still cannot be sung without crying, in the old prayers that have

CHAPTER EIGHT

What the Church Owes the Deconstructors

This chapter is for the pastors, the parents, the elders, the small-group leaders, the church members who have watched someone they love walk away and have not known what to do. It is the hardest chapter in the book, because the one indicted most severely is the church itself, and the church includes the people writing and reading these words. This word is not handed down from a platform. It is handed across a table.

THE DEBTS WE HAVE NOT PAID

We owe them the truth about what we have been, and what we have covered up, and what we have gotten wrong. The first debt is truth-telling, and it is not the deconstructor's job to drag it out of us. We should be the

This means pastors saying, from the pulpit — not on social media, not in a carefully worded statement, but on a Sunday morning — that we have defended things that should not have been defended. We have made the gospel sound like a tribal banner. We have let celebrity culture into our movement and protected celebrities at the cost of victims. We have confused the kingdom of God with a political project. We have preached purity in ways that crushed the people we were charged to guard. Specific sins named specifically, without the passive voice, without the softening adjectives. The deconstructors are watching to see whether we can do this. Almost none of them expect us to. The pastor who does it will find that some of the deconstructors in his extended family appear in the back pew on a Sunday he did not expect. Some will not. Some will need more time. All of them will know, for the first time in years, that the truth is speakable in this building.

We owe them honest engagement with the questions, not culture-war answers. A deconstructor asks about the violence in the Old Testament, and we do not get to hand over a four-sentence apologetic and return to sermon prep. We have to wrestle with the text alongside them. We have to be able to articulate more than one faithful Christian response to the hard passages and let the person

We owe them a theology of suffering. The American church has been preaching, in many of its expressions, a functional theology of breakthrough that falls apart the first time life hits a wall. We have to replace it with the New Testament's actual theology of suffering. Paul wrote half the New Testament from prison. Peter told his readers to count it a privilege to share in Christ's sufferings. James opened his letter with instructions about trials. Jesus told his disciples plainly:

■ *In the world you will have tribulation.*

— JOHN 16:33

The book of Job sits in the middle of the Bible for a reason, and its answer is not why the suffering came but who God is in the middle of it. This is not optional material. It is the spine of the tradition. A church that has misplaced it has to recover it. The people we have been losing hit walls we told them would never come. We have to tell them the truth about walls and about what God does inside them.

We owe them the whole Bible, not only the parts that support our tribe's current position. This means we preach through books. We sit inside a text. We let Scripture ask us hard questions rather than only supply answers to the questions we were already asking. We stop using verses like credentials and start reading the Bible like the strange, difficult, living document it is. We let

SPACE TO GRIEVE OUT LOUD

We owe them space to grieve out loud. We have to make the church a place where a woman can speak of her miscarriages and no one tells her God has a plan. Where a young man can say he has cancer and no one tells him God will not give him more than he can handle. Where someone walks in one Sunday with red eyes and the person in the next seat can say I see you and ask nothing further. Where the prayer requests in the bulletin include my marriage is dying, or my child has stopped speaking to me, or I am afraid I am losing my faith. Real requests about real lives, not only the sanitized surgery requests everyone has always felt safe sharing.

*The moment the church becomes a
performance space, we lose the
grieving. The moment we lose the*

The deconstructors left in part because the performance was too loud. We have to turn it off. We have to start being people again. This is slow work, and it starts with the pastor. If the pastor is performing, everyone is performing. If the pastor is a real person, the room will, very slowly, give itself permission to be real too.

WELCOME WITHOUT COMPROMISE

We owe them a posture of welcome without compromise. This is the balance the American church has had the hardest time holding. Some churches have welcomed so expansively that they no longer stand for anything. Others have drawn lines so aggressively that welcome has disappeared. Jesus held both at once. He invited Matthew to dinner without pretending Matthew's extortion was fine. He forgave the woman at the well without pretending she had been well. He received tax collectors and prostitutes and sinners while calling them, consistently, to a different life. The posture was welcome. The ethic was costly.

The deconstructors are not, mostly, asking for the ethic to be removed. They are asking for the welcome to be real. They want to come with their questions, their scars, their partial faith, and be received as human beings on a path rather than as problems to be solved. A church that can hold that posture will see some of them return. A church that cannot will not.

We owe them honesty about ourselves, and our own repentance, visible and costly. The deconstructor is tired of pastors who are too polished. They want to see the cracks. They want to know what the pastor has doubted, what he has repented of, what he still has not figured out. This is not a call for performative vulnerability. Performative vulnerability is the new polish. It is a call for the real thing, which is far harder, because it means risking one's authority and discovering that, paradoxically, authority is gained by risking it.

Consider the pastor who stood up one Sunday and said: I do not know why my daughter is not well. I have prayed every prayer I know. Nothing has helped. I am going to preach the text now, because the text is true whether my daughter is well or not, but I wanted you to know where I am. That sermon is still mentioned in that congregation ten years later — not for the exegesis, for the honesty. The deconstructors in that church heard something they had not heard from a pulpit in a long time. They heard a man who was not performing.

Most pastors are going to have to do some version of this. It is not a one-time announcement. It is a posture held over years. The pastor who walks in it will find, slowly, that the reputation of his ministry inside his own home, his own church, his own community, becomes the reputation of a man who tells the truth even when it costs him. That reputation is the only currency with which a pastor can do anything of lasting worth. We have to pay for it. It is worth what it costs. And where churches have driven people out, the people who led them owe a specific apology, a willingness to sit down and hear what went

THE LONG GAME

We owe them the long game. A deconstructor who walks away today may come back in three years, or seven, or seventeen. The church's task is to remain the same church they could come back to. That means we stay known. We do not go silent when they leave. We send the Christmas card. We ask after them when we see their parents. We do not push. We do not guilt. We keep the door open without making the door a trap. Some will come home. Some will not. The faithfulness is in the staying, not in the return rate.

The American church, taken as a whole, has not yet done what it would take to earn the return of the people it has lost. We have not repented publicly at the scale our failures demand. We have not reformed our pulpits on the matters most in question. We have not rebuilt the trust we squandered. We are not yet a community most deconstructors could reasonably return to. That is not an indictment of every local congregation. There are churches doing this work quietly, faithfully, in places no one is watching. They are the seeds of the church that will be. Most of us have more work to do.

If you are a pastor who recognizes yourself and your church in what has been named here, the response is not despair. The response is to begin. Begin tomorrow. Begin the sermon you have been afraid to preach. Begin the repentance you have been avoiding. Begin the conversation with the person whose number is still in your

A WORD TO THE ONE WHO STAYED UNTIL THE END

To the deconstructor who has made it to the end of this book: no one here knows what you are going to decide, and no one is trying to manipulate you into a decision. The aim is only to tell you the truth that has been found, so that whatever you decide, you decide with the truth available to you. The church you left may not be a church worth returning to. Jesus is still worth returning to. The church at her best — and she is not always at her best — is the body that carries him forward in the world. Find her. Or let her find you. She is not always who she has seemed to be. Underneath the accretions, she is the people of God, and you are welcome among them, and we have been praying for you in ways you do not know. Come when you are ready. Stay away if you need to. Either way, we love you, and the Shepherd has not taken his eyes off you.

CHAPTER NINE

The Sociology of Loss

Every generation has its doubters, and every era has produced people who set down the faith they were handed. What the American church is watching now is different in scale and in character. The question is not whether people leave; they always have. The question is why this generation, raised in this version of American Christianity, is leaving at rates with no precedent in the modern history of the church. Answering that honestly means setting down the explanation most pastors reach for first — that the culture got worse and faithfulness got harder — and picking up a harder set of tools.

That preferred explanation is not entirely wrong. The culture has shifted. Secularism has advanced. The plausibility structures that once made belief in God seem obvious have weakened, and Charles Taylor has given the church language for it. We live in what he called the immanent frame: a cultural condition in which the natural order feels like the only order, and the transcendent must be argued for rather than assumed. The shift is real, and it

But the culture-is-worse account is incomplete, and often self-serving. It lets the church off the hook. It treats the loss as external weather rather than internal rot. The generational data does not support the claim that American secularism alone accounts for the scale of the departure. Secularism advanced in Europe for a century, and the American church watched European decline for decades while congratulating itself on being different. Something else happened here, in the last forty years, that broke the trust. The culture cannot explain it. Only the church can.

*The institution reads the exit as
apostasy. The young person reads it as
integrity.*

The deconstruction wave is a delayed reckoning with specific choices the American church made in the last generation, and the generational character of the exodus reveals that those choices carried an expiration date. The children and grandchildren of the people who made them are now adults. They are filing their assessments.

THE FAITH THAT CAME WRAPPED IN A

Consider what shaped this generation. They are the first Americans who grew up entirely inside a culture war the church was understood to be fighting. Their parents came of age in a church that was still, in some ways, a cultural default, a place where politics was present but not primary. By the 2010s the political valence of American evangelicalism was no longer implicit. It was the thing. You could not attend a large evangelical church in those years without meeting political signaling as a core feature of the experience. The worship service wrapped itself in a flag. The sermons named the cultural enemies. The bookstore carried the campaign-season paperbacks. The faith these young people received was not a faith they could separate from the politics. By the time they were old enough to think about it, they could not imagine evangelical Christianity as anything but a political tribe that happened to have a god.

That was a choice the church made. It did not have to make it. There were voices at the time warning against it, and those voices were marginalized. The choice was made anyway, because political alignment felt like power, and power felt like the way to protect the things the church valued. A generation watched the church choose power, and that generation is now reporting what it saw. It saw a church that traded its soul for a seat at a table, that defended men who should not have been defended, that endorsed candidates whose character violated everything the church claimed to care about, and that justified all of it with appeals to lesser-evil calculation that, when pressed, turned into appeals to tribal loyalty. The young person in the pew lacked the theological vocabulary to articulate

A generation that senses its elders did not mean what they said does not leave the faith first. It leaves the institution. It says, in effect, I will keep Jesus but I will not keep this church, because this church has shown me that its public commitments are negotiable and its private commitment is to power. The institution reads the exit as apostasy. The young person reads it as integrity. The tragedy is that the young person is more often right than wrong, and the institution lacks the self-knowledge to hear it.

This is why so many deconstruction stories share a shape. They do not begin with a doctrinal objection. They begin with a moral revulsion. Something happened, in the home church or in the national news, that exposed the gap between what the church said and what the church did. The young person raised the gap, usually first to a parent, and was shut down. Raised it to a pastor, and was told they were being influenced by the world. Raised it in Bible study, and watched the adults rally to defend whatever had exposed the gap. The young person learned that the church did not want the conversation, that the adults in the room had decided the answer in advance, and that anyone who pushed against it would be reframed as the problem. The deconstruction was already underway. They had not yet left the building. They had already left the trust.

RAISED BY THE INTERNET

A second factor is more diffuse and equally important. This is the first generation that grew up with the internet.

This is not a failure on their part. It is a feature of the world they were given. Any church strategy that assumes the young person can be persuaded to trust the institution on the institution's own say-so is running on a model of trust that expired before the young person was born. In the medium of the internet, trust is earned by transparency, by acknowledgment of mistakes, by willingness to be contradicted, and by consistency over time. None of these are strengths of the American evangelical institution. It was built for a different media ecosystem and has not adapted. Its habits of speech and its rhythms of crisis management belong to an era when it could control the conversation. That era is over. The institution has not caught up.

A third factor: this generation has a different relationship to suffering than the generations before it, and the relationship deserves to be taken seriously before it is dismissed. They have been told, from kindergarten forward, that their feelings matter, that pain is real, that trauma is a legitimate category of experience, and that healing is a legitimate goal. Some of this is cultural excess. Some is therapeutic language escaping the clinical setting where it belongs. But some of it is a genuine correction against the emotional repression that shaped earlier generations. The correction has limits. It can slide into a self-absorbed fragility that treats every discomfort as trauma. But it is not nothing, and the church that wants to minister to this generation has to meet it inside its emotional vocabulary, not outside it.

The problem is that much of American evangelical preaching runs on an implicit anthropology that treats emotional pain as a sign of insufficient faith. The young person comes forward with real grief, real anxiety, real depression, and is given a verse. The verse is not wrong. The verse is insufficient. They needed a verse and a human being. They got half. When they go outside the church and find a therapist who takes their pain seriously for the first time in their life, the therapist earns their trust in a way the church never did. The church then reads the therapist's influence as secular drift. The young person reads it as someone finally listening. It is not hard to see who keeps the relationship.

THE COST OF INSTITUTIONAL SILENCE

A pastor who likes this sort of answer can complain about the generation's insistence on consistency. He can call them self-righteous, ungracious, naive about institutions made of flawed people. Each charge is partially true. But the deeper truth is that this generation learned its standards of institutional behavior from the same institutions it is now criticizing. The church taught them that character matters, that hypocrisy is a sin, that leaders should be above reproach. They absorbed the teaching. They applied it to the teachers. The teachers failed the test. The students are now behaving exactly as the teachers told them to behave. The teachers do not like being held to the standard they set.

THE COLLAPSE OF DEFERENCE

A fifth factor is more subtle. This generation has a

The framework can be argued with. It is probably too cynical, and saying so is fair. But it cannot be wished away. The church that ministers to this generation has to understand that trust in authority itself sits at historic lows, that the church does not get a pass on that larger distrust, and that it will have to earn trust the way every other institution now does. The era when the church could expect deference because it was the church is over. The era when a pastor's word carried automatic weight because of the role is over. The role is not gone. The deference is.

THE WORK THAT REMAINS

What does this mean for the pastor who takes the generational character of the exit seriously? A few things. First, take the institutional critique on its own terms rather than reframing it as a spiritual problem. The young person

Second, accept the internet reality. The competition is no longer the Gospel of Thomas. It is a forty-minute, well-sourced podcast on the denomination's recent abuse coverup, and the young person will hear it. That cannot be prevented. What can be built is a kind of leader whose response is credible: the pastor who names the failure from the pulpit before the young person asks, who meets a local case of pastoral misconduct not by rushing to defend the accused but by committing to due process with a bias toward the vulnerable, whose answer to institutional failure is institutional repentance rather than damage control. The young person is watching, and will notice.

Third, develop a pastoral theology of emotional experience that does not treat feelings as a category to be corrected with doctrine. Feelings are data. They are not the final word, but they are data. A person in real grief needs Scripture and also needs to be allowed to grieve. A person with real anxiety needs the Psalms and also needs to be told the anxiety is not a sin. A person who has endured real trauma needs the cross and also needs to be told that what happened was not God's will, that God grieves with them, that the way through is longer than a verse. The church that cannot say those things will lose the

Fourth, understand that the demand for moral consistency is not going away, and do not resent it. A generation that grew up watching institutions betray their own stated values will not extend credit to any institution, this one included, on the strength of a claim. Credit is earned, repeatedly, by action. To keep the young person, a pastor and a church have to match practice to preaching and answer the inevitable mismatch with honest confession rather than spin. This is not a lowering of the bar. It is a return to the bar the church set and then mostly abandoned.

Fifth, remember that the generation is not uniform. Some will leave no matter what. Some will return later. Some are in the middle, watchful, looking for signs. The ones in the middle are the ones a faithful pastor can still reach — not by performance, but by the slow, unglamorous work of being a pastor whose integrity the young person can check against reality.

The sociology of the loss is not destiny. The generational factors are not deterministic. Individual pastors and individual congregations can still make a difference, but the difference will be made only by leaders who understand what the young person is actually experiencing — which is not a failure of cultural faithfulness in a hostile environment, but a reckoning with specific choices the American church made over the last forty years, now that the young person has had time to assess them. Louder preaching will not stop it. Harder catechism will not stop it. It will be stopped, where it is stopped at all, by churches that repent of what was wrong,



Whoever conceals his transgressions will not prosper, but he who confesses and forsakes them will obtain mercy.

— PROVERBS 28:13

That is the work. It is slower than a program and harder than a conference, and it is the only thing that will hold.

CHAPTER TEN

Science, Creation, and the False Choice

Consider the young man raised in a household where evolution was a lie, the universe was six thousand years old, and the geological record was the residue of Noah's flood. He is thirty now. Two semesters of college biology, a few books on cosmology read for pleasure, and he concluded that the scientific account of the natural world is, on its own terms, compelling. He did not set out to reject his childhood faith. He set out to understand the world. The rejection followed because the adults in his life, and the books they handed him, had told him that to accept the scientific account was to reject the Bible. He accepted the account. He assumed the rejection was required. No one had given him the resources to think otherwise.

This story is not rare. It is one of the most common shapes deconstruction takes, and it is entirely preventable. The preventability is what makes it infuriating.

This chapter will say things that will be uncomfortable for pastors and congregations that have built their identity on a young-earth, anti-evolutionary posture. The point is not to ask anyone to abandon convictions. The point is that the posture be held with an honesty that has too often been missing. Hold the young-earth position, if you must, because you have weighed the arguments on both sides and concluded it has the better of them. Do not hold it because you have been told that to hold otherwise is to deny the faith. That claim is historically false, theologically shallow, and pastorally catastrophic. It is responsible, directly, for the loss of a significant share of the young people who have left the evangelical church over the last thirty years. The blood is on the hands of the leaders who taught them that the Bible required a posture it does not,

WHAT THE TEXT IS FOR

The opening chapters of Genesis are extraordinary pieces of ancient literature. They function as theological polemic against the surrounding creation myths of the ancient Near East, and they make their argument by borrowing the structural features of those myths while subverting their content. The other accounts featured gods in conflict, humans made from the blood of defeated deities to serve as slaves, and a cosmos that was precarious and arbitrary. Genesis 1 and 2 feature one God who speaks the world into being, humans made in the divine image with royal dignity, and a cosmos that is ordered and good. This is the theological work the text is doing. It tells the Israelites what kind of world they live in, what kind of God made it, and what kind of creatures they are inside it. This is what the text is for.

What the text is not for is what a modern scientific textbook is for. It is not providing a chronology of the geological record. It is not specifying the mechanisms by which species arose. It is not offering an astronomical account of stellar formation. The questions a scientist asks are not the questions the text was written to answer. To force the text to answer them, and then to grade the answer against the findings of modern science, is to misuse the text in a way its own authors would not recognize. The early church fathers knew this. They read Genesis 1 allegorically, figuratively, and symbolically as readily as they read it literally, and they saw no conflict in doing so, because they understood the text to be a different genre than natural history.

None of this means the young-earth position is without serious defenders today, or that every argument for it is bad. Some of its defenders are careful and honest. But the framing handed down to most American evangelical young people is neither. The framing holds that to accept an old earth is to compromise biblical authority, that to accept common descent is to deny the gospel, and that any Christian who accepts the mainstream scientific account has been captured by the world. This framing is false at every level. The history of Christian interpretation does not support it. The theology of Scripture does not require it. And its pastoral fruit is, as we are watching in real time, catastrophic.

Jesus did not die for six-day creation.

The gospel is not contingent on the age

Put it more directly. If the cost of holding the young-earth line has been that a significant portion of the rising generation has concluded that Christianity itself is intellectually indefensible, then the line has been too expensive. The church has survived every previous scientific revolution, including the Copernican one, which was far more threatening to its worldview than anything on offer today. It survived because, every time, Christian thinkers did the hard work of showing that the faith could hold the new knowledge without losing its core. The church that refuses that work now is not defending the gospel. It is abandoning the young people the gospel exists to save.

THE WORD DOING TOO MUCH WORK

A word about evolution, because the term is doing so much work in so many Christian conversations that it has nearly lost its meaning. In mainstream biology, evolution refers to the change in heritable traits in a population across generations, through mechanisms that include natural selection, genetic drift, and mutation. It is among the best-supported theories in the history of science, confirmed by converging evidence from paleontology, comparative anatomy, molecular biology, and the direct observation of populations over time. The evidence is not controversial among working biologists.

What is sometimes controversial is the philosophical extrapolation: the claim that evolution demonstrates the

A Christian can hold that God is the creator, that human beings bear the divine image, that the soul is real and non-reducible, that sin is catastrophic and in need of redemption, and that Jesus is the incarnate Son of God who died and rose again, while also accepting that the universe is roughly 13.8 billion years old, that the earth is 4.5 billion years old, that life developed through evolutionary processes, and that humans share common ancestors with other primates. Christians have held that synthesis for over a century. Many of the most influential theologians of the twentieth century, C. S. Lewis among them, held some form of it. The synthesis requires abandoning no core Christian conviction. It requires only abandoning the assumption that Genesis 1 and 2 were written to function as a scientific account. That assumption is not biblical. It is cultural.

ONE THING TO STOP DOING

The pastor not ready to adopt the synthesis is not being asked to. He is being asked to do one thing. Stop telling the young people in the congregation that accepting mainstream science is the same as rejecting the Bible. Stop because it is false, and stop because the cost is unconscionable. A pastor can hold his interpretive position without requiring his entire congregation to hold

Augustine, in his commentary on Genesis, warned explicitly against Christians making definitive interpretive claims about Scripture in areas where natural philosophy was still being worked out, because he saw that such overconfidence would turn outsiders away from the faith over nothing. He was right in the fourth century. He is right now. Many of the young people lost in recent years have lost their faith over exactly the thing Augustine warned against. The warning has been available for sixteen hundred years. The church that did not listen is now counting the cost.

Turn, briefly, to the positive case. A Christianity that can receive the findings of modern science is not a diminished Christianity. It is, in some ways, a richer one. The universe is older, larger, and stranger than the young-earth framework allowed. Read against the backdrop of cosmology, the creation story is not less awe-inspiring but more. Billions of years of stars forming and dying to forge the heavy elements that make up a human body. Galaxies colliding across timescales that dwarf the whole human story. Life developing on one small planet through mechanisms whose elegance is its own argument for design. The doctrine of creation, as it turns out, was never small enough to fit inside six literal days. The text was pointing toward something grander than the readings imposed on it. The grand thing is still there, if we will let the text be what it is and let the creation speak in its own voice.

The young person told all his life that to follow the evidence is to leave the faith hears that frame as an

This is not a compromise. It is the historic Christian confidence. It is the faith of Augustine, of Aquinas, of C. S. Lewis. It is what the tradition has looked like, most of the time, when it was operating at its best. The American evangelical movement of the last century narrowed the tradition to an interpretive position the tradition never uniformly held, then presented that narrow position as the only faithful one. That was a mistake. It has been a costly one. It is not too late to stop making it.

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN A LOCAL CHURCH

Begin in the pulpit. Preach through Genesis 1 and 2 as the ancient theological literature they are, and let the text do what it was written to do. Show the congregation the polemical work the text performs against the surrounding cultures. Show them the poetic structure, the Hebrew wordplay, the way the text reserves the image of God for every human being, a radical claim in its original context. Do this before a word is said about days and dinosaurs. Let the congregation see that the text is not small.

When the scientific questions do come, address them with honesty about what the text claims and does not claim, and with humility about the interpretive options the

Build, in the congregation, a curiosity about the natural world that reflects the goodness of creation. Take the people outside. Show them the telescopes. Let them see that the world God made is an endless source of wonder, and that Christians have no reason to fear any of it. A congregation that loves the world God made will be harder to shake when the world turns up something unexpected.

When young people arrive with questions that grew out of their science classes, do not shut them down. Do not call their college biology professor a Marxist ideologue. Do not hand them a DVD from 1998 that purports to debunk carbon dating. Listen to the question. Take it seriously. Say: I do not know everything about this. Let me look into it, and get back to you. That sentence, from a pastor, is worth more than a thousand confident wrong answers.

Find the books and the resources. The BioLogos organization, founded by Francis Collins, has done good work helping Christians engage the scientific questions without losing the faith. Alister McGrath has written carefully and well. John Polkinghorne, before his death, produced a body of work any pastor can point a questioning young person toward. The resources exist. Use them. Stop handing young people the books from the 1980s that pretended dinosaurs and humans walked together. Those books were wrong when they were written,

THE BATTLE THAT WAS NEVER REQUIRED

The old battle, between a flat-footed biblical literalism and mainstream science, was a battle the church was always going to lose, because it was fought on terms the church never needed to accept. The choice was never between the Bible and science. The choice was between a recent American evangelical reading of Genesis and the findings of the natural sciences. The reading can be corrected. The sciences will not be rolled back.

A faith that has defined itself by the reading is a faith hemorrhaging the generation that followed the sciences. A faith that defines itself by the person of Jesus Christ can hold the sciences, ask larger questions than the sciences ask, and offer answers the sciences cannot give. That faith is still available. The young person who left over the false choice is still reachable, if the church will give him the faith it should have given him in the first place.

If what we think the Bible teaches conflicts with what we can demonstrate about the world, let us reexamine our reading; the God who wrote the one also authored the other.

— AFTER AUGUSTINE, DE GENESI AD LITTERAM

The warning is sixteen centuries old. The history of the interpretive options is a matter of public record. The next generation can be told the truth and trusted to think, with

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Problem of Hell Revisited

For many who deconstruct, hell is the doctrine that pushes them over the edge. They can live with the tension between providence and suffering. They can live with the stranger corners of the Old Testament. They can live with the church's political captivity by holding their nose and finding a different congregation. What they cannot live with is a doctrine of eternal conscious torment preached as the plain reading of Scripture, presented as though any Christian who held otherwise had denied the faith. The doctrine, as they received it, made God a moral monster. The monster did not match the Jesus of the Gospels. The mismatch became unsupportable, and faith broke.

This chapter attempts something careful. The argument is that the church, in much of its talk about hell, has been louder than the Bible, more confident than the tradition, and less pastoral than the doctrine itself requires. It is also that the popular evangelical position is

THE WORD THAT DOES TOO MUCH

Start with the vocabulary. The English word hell renders several different words from the biblical languages in most translations, and those words do not all mean the same thing. The Hebrew Sheol referred, in most Old Testament usage, to the grave or the underworld, a shadowy place where the dead, righteous and wicked alike, were understood to go. It was not primarily a place of torment. The Greek Hades, used in the Septuagint to translate Sheol and then again in the New Testament, carries a similar range. Gehenna, the word on Jesus' lips in the Gospels, refers literally to the Valley of Hinnom outside Jerusalem, a place the prophets associated with terrible judgment because of the idolatry committed there. Tartarus, used once in 2 Peter, names a pit for fallen angels. Four words, four ranges of meaning. Collapsing them into one English word carrying one doctrinal content is already a translation decision, and it shapes what the reader thinks the Bible says.

A young person who meets these facts for the first time, often in a college religion course or on a podcast, is going to be disoriented. They were told the Bible had a clear

WHAT JESUS ACTUALLY SAID, AND WHAT HE QUOTED

Take the teaching of Jesus directly. He spoke about judgment a great deal, and the language was vivid and serious. Weeping and gnashing of teeth. Fire that is not quenched. The worm that does not die. These are terrifying images, and any honest reading of the Gospels must reckon with the fact that he used them. What is less clear, from the texts themselves, is what he meant by them. The images come from the Old Testament, particularly from Isaiah, where the unquenchable fire and the undying worm describe the corpses of those judged outside Jerusalem:

*And they shall go out and look on the dead bodies of
the men who have rebelled against me. For their
worm shall not die, their fire shall not be quenched,
and they shall be an abhorrence to all flesh.*

— ISAIAH 66:24

The referent is corpses, not living beings in conscious torment. The fire burns and the worm consumes because there is nothing left to burn or consume, not because the

Does that settle what Jesus meant? No. But it means the confident claim, made from many pulpits, that Jesus clearly taught eternal conscious torment is overstated. He used images whose original referent was the destruction of the wicked, and he applied them to the final judgment. Whether he intended those images to carry the old referent forward, which is destruction, or to transform them into something new, which is endless torment, is a matter on which careful Christians have disagreed.

THREE POSITIONS, ALL OF THEM ORTHODOX

Three positions have a long history in the church and have been held by Christians who were, by any reasonable measure, serious and orthodox. The first is eternal conscious torment, the default most American evangelicals received. It holds that the wicked, at the final judgment, are consigned to a state of conscious suffering that never ends. It draws support from certain readings of Matthew 25 and Revelation 20, and it was held by some of the early fathers. The second is conditional immortality, sometimes called annihilationism. It holds that the wicked are destroyed, so that their existence ends. It was held by some early fathers, has been defended in the modern period by careful evangelicals like John Stott and Edward Fudge, and has significant support from the language of destruction, perishing, and the second death that runs through the New Testament. The third is universal reconciliation, sometimes called Christian universalism. It

The argument here is not for one of these over the others. It is that the evangelical church has often presented the first as though the other two did not exist or were self-evidently heretical. That presentation is historically false and pastorally ruinous. Many who walked away from Christianity over hell walked away from a version the tradition as a whole never unanimously held, and they walked away because no one ever told them there were other options.

Why did no one tell them? Partly because the leaders they trusted did not know. Much American evangelical pastoral training, especially outside the seminaries that do careful work, never exposes pastors to the full range of the tradition on this question. A pastor who has only encountered eternal conscious torment will assume it is the only option and preach it that way. Partly because the doctrine has been used, in too many settings, as an evangelistic lever, and weakening the lever feels like weakening the evangelism. Partly because there is a cultural fear, understandable but not defensible, that opening the question will collapse into universalism, and that universalism removes all urgency from the Christian life. None of these rises to the level of a good reason for silence about the actual range of Christian thought.

WHAT THE YOUNG PERSON WAS NEVER

Consider that even on the most traditional reading, hell is not something God does to people. It is, on most careful accounts, the state of the soul that has decisively and finally refused God. C. S. Lewis put it as memorably as anyone: the door of hell is locked on the inside. The wicked, on this view, are not screaming to get out while God holds them in. They are in the state they have chosen, separation from the love they rejected, and the suffering is the shape of that rejection made permanent. This is not the cartoon. The cartoon, with its red devil and pitchfork and gleeful God of vengeance, owes more to Dante and to medieval Italian painting than to anything the Bible teaches or the serious tradition has held.

Consider that the New Testament writers, when they speak of final judgment, lean heavily on the language of perishing, destruction, and death. The wages of sin is death, not eternal life in torment. The broad road leads to destruction. The chaff is burned up. The branch is cut off and burned. These images can be read in support of eternal conscious torment, but they can also, with equal textual legitimacy, be read in support of a view in which the unredeemed cease to be. Conditional immortality has gained serious support among evangelical scholars over the last half century for exactly this reason. It fits the language of the New Testament better than its critics admit, and it resolves the moral problem the young person is raising in a way the first position cannot.

Many who rejected the doctrine of hell

Consider that the early church did not operate with one unified doctrine of hell and did not treat disagreement here as the line between orthodoxy and heresy. Gregory of Nyssa, whose trinitarian theology is foundational for orthodox Christianity, was a universalist. Origen, more controversially, held a version of the same view. The council that eventually censured certain universalist positions, the Fifth Ecumenical Council in 553, ratified a position that had already become dominant, but it did not eliminate the disagreement entirely, and it did not retroactively declare Gregory of Nyssa a heretic. The orthodox tradition has had more room on this question than most contemporary evangelicals realize. That room is available.

Consider, finally, that the motivation behind the doctrine as it has been taught is frequently a desire to protect the seriousness of the gospel. That motivation is not wrong. The gospel is serious, the stakes are real, and any account of judgment that dissolves the seriousness has given something up. But a doctrine can guard seriousness in more than one way. A doctrine that says the unrepentant perish and cease to be is serious. A doctrine that says the unrepentant are finally reconciled after a refining judgment is serious. The seriousness does not require the specific picture of eternal torment to do its

WHAT A PASTOR SHOULD DO

What should a pastor do with all of this, given that most congregations are not ready for a fifteen-week seminary lecture on the history of eschatological thought?

First, stop preaching confident claims that exceed the evidence. A pastor who has held a version of eternal conscious torment for most of his ministry can continue to hold it while acknowledging that other serious Christians have held other positions. That acknowledgment costs almost nothing from the pulpit and buys the young person a reason to stay. The alternative is an overclaiming that, once the young person discovers the truth about the history of Christian thought, will look like dishonesty and cost the preacher every ounce of credibility he had.

Second, when preaching on judgment, focus on the person of the Judge rather than the mechanics of the sentence. The Judge is Jesus. The Jesus of the Gospels is the one who will judge. If that reframing creates problems, good; let them do their work. The cartoon Jesus who loves unconditionally in this life and then presides over eternal torture in the next is not the Jesus of the Gospels. He is a figure stitched together from half-read texts. The real Jesus is more complicated and more trustworthy than that.

Third, take the moral objection seriously rather than dismissing it as a sign the objector does not understand holiness. The young person who says, I cannot worship a God who would eternally torture people for a finite life of finite sin, is making an argument every serious Christian has had to wrestle with. One may disagree with the

Fourth, recover the tradition. Read Gregory of Nyssa. Read Origen. Read Edward Fudge. Read John Stott and watch an evangelical statesman defend conditional immortality in careful biblical terms. Read David Bentley Hart's *That All Shall Be Saved*, not in order to agree with it, but in order to see what a serious defense of universalism actually looks like rather than the caricature so often handed down. Read the Catholic tradition on purgatory, which is not the same as hell but illuminates how the tradition has thought about the posthumous condition. Let the tradition talk back. The reader will come out with more respect for the positions he still does not hold and more humility about the ones he does.

Fifth, preach the love of God with the same confidence the wrath of God has been preached. The New Testament does not grant the right to separate these. The cross of Christ is simultaneously the revelation of wrath and of love, and any preaching that has emphasized one without the other has handed the congregation a half-gospel. If a decade of sermons has been heavy on judgment and light on love, the balance needs correcting. Not because love is the only thing, but because love is the larger thing. The wrath exists inside the love, not alongside it. A God who does not love is not the Christian God. A God who only threatens is not the Christian God either.

To the young person who left over hell, the matter can be put directly. The moral objection was not a sign of spiritual weakness. It was a sign of moral seriousness. The doctrine as it was received deserved the objection. What was missing was the rest of the conversation, and the rest of the conversation is available. No one has to accept the cartoon. No one has to accept the version handed out in youth group by a leader who had never thought carefully about it. The texts can be read with fresh eyes. The tradition can be opened. A person can come back to a faith that turns out to be bigger and stranger and more humane than the one they rejected.

The God of the Bible is not a torturer. The God of the Bible is the Father who runs to meet the prodigal while he is still a long way off. The Judge of the final judgment is the same Judge who wept over Jerusalem:



O Jerusalem, Jerusalem, the city that kills the prophets and stones those who are sent to it! How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you were not willing!

— MATTHEW 23:37

Whatever final judgment means, it means something consistent with that Judge, because that Judge is who he is. The doctrine of hell, held honestly, has to be held inside that portrait. Held outside it, it becomes something other than the Christian doctrine, and the young person who rejected it was often rejecting something the tradition itself had partly rejected. Come back and ask again. Ask

CHAPTER TWELVE

Sexuality, the Body, and the Scriptural Imagination

The Bible is more sexually conservative than most of the cultural options on offer today. That is not the difficult claim. The difficult claim is the one the sexual ethics debate is rarely allowed to reach: that so many people leave the faith over the church's handling of sexuality when the underlying ethic, rightly understood, is not actually where the problem lies. The problem lies somewhere else. The young person who left needs the church to be honest about where.

Here is the honest diagnosis. The church is losing people over sexuality not primarily because the biblical sexual ethic is too demanding, though it is, but because the church has paired that ethic with a set of ancillary commitments that are indefensible. The one who walks away is often not walking away from the ethic. They are

The package has to be disassembled before the ethic can be heard. What follows is some of that disassembly.

WHAT PURITY CULTURE DID

Begin with purity culture, the most immediate source of pain for a significant portion of the deconstruction wave. As it was practiced in American evangelicalism from the 1990s into the 2010s, it made promises it could not keep and inflicted damage it did not measure. It promised young women that their worth was located in their unbroken state and that God had a specific spouse waiting for those who remained pure. It promised young men that they could control their lust through willpower and accountability partners, and that any failure was a moral catastrophe. It gave both a shared language that treated sexual sin as uniquely defiling, worse than other sins, and the sinner as damaged in a way other sinners were not. It produced a generation of adults who entered marriage with wedding-night anxiety, who carried shame about ordinary desire as if the desire itself were the sin, and who,

The church has barely begun to reckon with what this did. The book that launched much of the movement, *I Kissed Dating Goodbye*, was eventually retracted by its own author, who now speaks publicly about the harm it caused and his own subsequent departure from the faith. That retraction should have been a moment of widespread institutional reflection. It was instead largely ignored by the leaders who had promoted the book, because institutional self-protection is the default instinct of institutions, and acknowledging that the movement did harm would cost too much. The young women who were told that their sexual history made them, in the analogy of the chewed gum or the used cup, permanently diminished, are now adult women. They have therapists. They have marriages that required years of rebuilding. They have a generation of younger women watching them and asking whether the faith they were raised in can be trusted at all. The institution still has not apologized.

A pastor serious about his congregation should apologize, from the pulpit, specifically, for what purity culture did. Not in general terms. Specifically. Name the teachings. Name the books. Name the conferences. Say: we held these things up and they hurt people. Here is what we got wrong. Here is what the biblical sexual ethic actually is, which is demanding but not shaming, and here is what your relationship to your own past looks like under grace. The confession does not surrender the ethic. It returns the ethic to its actual proportions and strips away the ancillary claims that were never biblical in the first place. Young

THE QUESTION THAT EMPTIES PEWS

Now the harder ground. Homosexuality has been, for a generation, the question over which more deconstruction has happened than any other. It is worth asking why. The biblical position is not unclear. The historic teaching of the church, across Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant traditions, was unanimous until very recently. The reasons for the teaching are not arbitrary. They emerge from a biblical anthropology in which the complementarity of male and female, the image of God borne together by humanity, and the creational pattern of marriage as a one-flesh union between a man and a woman form a coherent framework that does not accommodate same-sex sexual union. That argument has been made elsewhere and need not be repeated here. The point here is different. The way the church has carried the teaching has made the teaching unintelligible to a generation that is, in many ways, more morally serious than its elders. The teaching has been carried in ways that made it look like hatred. The generation watching has filed it as hatred, and the church is now scrambling to explain that the teaching is not what the generation has filed.

Some of the responsibility lies with the surrounding culture, which has done significant work to make any traditional sexual ethic look like bigotry. Give that point its due. But most of the responsibility lies with the church itself. The church spent thirty years, from roughly 1980 to 2010, pouring enormous political energy into fighting

It did not have to be this way. The church could have held the traditional teaching while refusing to make public-policy enforcement of that teaching its central political cause. It could have modeled singleness as a vocation rather than a failure state. It could have welcomed gay people into congregations as full participants in the life of the church, called to the same holiness as everyone else, in the same way that single heterosexual Christians have always been called. It could have developed a theology of friendship robust enough to bear the weight friendship carries in a church where celibacy is a real vocation. It did none of these things, or did them only in small corners. It chose political campaign work instead. The bill came due.

To the young person who has deconstructed over this issue, several things must be said, uncomfortable on both sides. First, the ethic itself, once the political baggage is stripped away, is not indefensible. It emerges from a biblical anthropology richer than the caricatures that have been handed down. Read Wesley Hill's *Washed and Waiting*. Read Eve Tushnet. Read Hill's own work on spiritual friendship. These are gay Christians who have held to the traditional teaching and articulated what it

Second, the way the question got litigated in public, as if the only options were full cultural affirmation and total exclusion, was not the only option. The church has options inside its own life that the culture war did not allow to develop. The question is not whether the church will bless gay marriage. The question is whether the church can be a place where a gay Christian who holds to a traditional sexual ethic can find community, friendship, vocational meaning, and full participation in the life of the congregation, or whether the church will be a place that implicitly or explicitly tells that Christian to go somewhere else. The first is possible. The second is sin. Most American evangelical churches have defaulted to the second by omission, not by design, but the omission is not innocent.

Third, the way the church has treated gay people who are not Christians has done enormous damage to the gospel's public witness. The young person who watched the gay uncle ostracized by Christian relatives, who watched the conservative church lobby against a gay friend's adoption rights, who heard the joke from the pulpit about the transgender person, who file cabinets full of evidence that the church is not, at least not for gay people, a place of grace. That evidence cannot be unseen. The church that wants the young person to reconsider its position on the ethic has first to repent of the evidence. Not spin. Not reframing. Repentance. The specific

BODIES, GIVENNESS, AND THE LIMITS OF THE CHURCH'S WISDOM

Fourth, transgender questions have entered the church's attention with extraordinary speed, and most churches do not yet have the theological or pastoral resources to engage them well. There are things that can be said. Bodies are meaningful. The male-female distinction is not incidental to the human person. The Christian tradition has resources for honoring the body without treating the body's givenness as a cage. There are also things that have to be said about the limits of the church's wisdom here. The phenomenon of rapid-onset gender dysphoria among adolescent girls, which has produced a surge of medical interventions whose long-term outcomes are poorly understood, is a different question than the question of adult transsexuals who have lived in a transitioned identity for decades. The church that flattens all of these into a single ideological target has not done the work the question requires. The church that uncritically accepts every affirmation claim and shrugs off the serious moral and medical concerns has also not done the work. The work is harder than either tribal position allows.

A serious pastoral posture on transgender questions will have a few features. It will insist that every person who experiences gender dysphoria is an image-bearer, not a

This posture is going to disappoint the loudest voices in the culture war. The progressive voices will say it is not affirming enough. The reactive voices will say it is too accommodating. The pastoral posture is not trying to win the culture war. It is trying to minister to the actual human beings who are suffering in front of it, while holding to the anthropology the faith has always taught, and doing so with the humility the complexity of the questions requires. That posture is harder than either political alternative. It is also the only one a serious pastor can hold for long.

AN ANTHROPOLOGY OF THE BODY

The deeper issue beneath all of this, the one that feeds every individual question, is the church's anthropology of the body. Too much American evangelicalism, for too long,

The sexual ethic of the Bible is demanding because it takes bodies seriously, not because it despises them. Chastity outside of marriage is a call to honor the body by refusing to use it, or to be used, for purposes the covenantal framework of sexual union was not made to bear. Fidelity within marriage is a call to honor the body of the other as a gift rather than a possession. The ethic is exalted, not reductive. When it has been preached reductively, as a set of shaming rules and a management regime for desire, it has been preached as something other than what the Bible offers.

The ethic they resented was, in many cases, the caricature of the ethic. The actual ethic, held inside a congregation that treats bodies well, is not an instrument of oppression. It is a path, hard but not impossible,

A congregation that recovers a biblical anthropology of the body will be unrecognizable to one shaped by purity culture. It will be a congregation in which children are told that their bodies are good, that growing up is not embarrassing, that sexual desire is not a sign of spiritual failure. It will be a congregation in which single adults are not pitied as incomplete. It will be a congregation in which married couples speak about sex in ways neither puritanical nor crass, as a real and good part of the covenant they are living. It will be a congregation in which the gay member is not a category to be managed but a brother or sister whose call to holiness is the same as everyone else's, held inside a community that has thought hard about what friendship, hospitality, and family mean for every member. It will be a congregation in which the person who has made a mess of their sexuality is not consigned to the margins but met with the same grace that was extended to David, to the Samaritan woman, to the Corinthians.

THE THING ITSELF

This is the congregation the young person has been looking for. When they cannot find it, they leave. When they can find it, they stay, and sometimes they come back. The actual ethic, held inside a congregation that treats bodies well, is not what they resented. They resented the caricature. The one who has heard only the caricature has not heard the thing itself. They can still be offered the

The honesty this chapter has asked of the church can be tested in the pews. Where the goodness of the body, the dignity of desire, the exalted demandingness of the biblical ethic, and the grace that meets us inside all our failures with it have been preached, the preaching has met with relief. People have said, after services, that they heard something they had been waiting most of their lives to hear. They had been told the rules without being told the anthropology. They had been told to hate their desire without being told what their desire was for. They had been told their body was dangerous without being told it was a gift. Hearing the gift changed everything.

It can change everything for the one who deconstructed, too. The faith that frightened with its rules is still there, but the version that frightened was not the faith itself. The faith is larger. The faith is kinder. The faith takes the body more seriously, not less, than the cultural alternatives. The faith asks more. The asking is part of the gift.



So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them.

— GENESIS 1:27

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Spiritual Abuse Reckoning

There is a kind of deconstruction that begins with neither doctrine nor cultural discomfort nor the ordinary friction of religious life. It begins with a specific person, in a specific position of spiritual authority, who used that authority to harm a specific victim. The harm may have been sexual. It may have been financial. It may have been the slower, less visible harm of coercion, control, humiliation, and shame — perpetrated by the person and covered over by the institution. The victim walks out of that room changed. The faith taught inside that room is now tangled with the memory of what happened inside it. Pulling the two apart is the work of years.

A book on deconstruction that does not take this category seriously is not a serious book. Spiritual abuse is not rare. It has happened in the largest evangelical networks in America. It has happened in Catholic institutions across continents. It has happened in small

WHAT THE WORD NAMES

Spiritual abuse, as the scholarly literature on the phenomenon uses the term, is the use of spiritual authority to control, coerce, manipulate, or harm another person. It includes the obvious forms — pastoral sexual abuse, financial exploitation, physical violence by clergy or clergy-adjacent leaders. It also includes the forms that never reach a courtroom.

Shaming people in front of the congregation for disagreeing with the pastor. Weaponizing the membership covenant to punish dissent. Using the language of submission to silence victims. Deploying spiritual language to bypass ordinary ethical analysis — God has told me you need to do this, so the fact that it looks wrong is only your lack of faith. Coaching spouses to forgive abusers with no corresponding accountability for the abuser. Telling abuse victims to examine their own contribution to the abuse. Each of these is a form of spiritual abuse even when it does not rise to the level of a crime.

The harm is distinctive. It is not merely the harm of the abuse itself, which would be enough to ruin a life. It is the harm of the abuse being inflicted in the name of God, in

The victim who decides that the Christian faith is finally not credible has been given enormous reason to decide it. The question for the serious pastor is not whether that reason is sufficient. The question is whether the church responded the way it should have. In most cases, it did not.

THE INSTITUTIONAL REFLEX

When a pastor is credibly accused of sexual misconduct, the institution almost always delays. It convenes a committee. It consults lawyers. It asks whether there is enough for a lawsuit and weighs the reputational exposure. It urges the victim toward reconciliation and suggests that going public would hurt the mission. It encourages silence. It offers a severance package with a non-disclosure agreement, allows the pastor to resign with a face-saving letter, and declines to inform the other churches where he might next seek to be hired.

This pattern is not a feature of particular denominations or networks. It is a feature of the

The public cases that shaped the deconstruction wave are names the reader already knows. Ravi Zacharias, whose decades of apologetics covered decades of sexual predation that the institution he built knew about, or should have. Bill Hybels, whose Willow Creek spent years absorbing and denying credible allegations. The Southern Baptist Convention, whose 2022 investigation revealed a pattern of institutional cover-up across hundreds of cases. Individual pastors in every major network whose names became cautionary tales for a generation that watched the reveals in real time, watched the responses, and drew conclusions.

The conclusions were not about individual failures. They were about institutional character. The young person concluded that the evangelical church cannot be trusted with power over the vulnerable, that its public moralism was a cover for private predation, that the men in charge would sacrifice the people they were supposed to protect in order to hold their positions. She concluded, in short, that the institution was not what it claimed to be — and that the claims themselves were therefore suspect.

*She is watching an institution that
knows it has failed, knows it must*

One can argue that the conclusion overgeneralizes. One can point to the faithful pastors and the healthy congregations that do not fit the pattern. These arguments are not false. But they do not answer the deeper question: whether the institution that produced the failures is capable of the reforms that would prevent their recurrence, and whether it is telling the truth about the failures it has already acknowledged. On both counts the evidence is mixed at best. The Southern Baptist response to its own investigation was slower and weaker than the findings warranted. The proposed accountability structures have mostly gone unimplemented. The independent oversight that would force the institution to accept limits on its own authority has been resisted. The young person watching this knows exactly what she is watching.

WHAT A LOCAL PASTOR CAN DO

The national patterns lie beyond any one pastor's control. The local church does not. Five things are within reach, and each of them costs something.

First, name the crisis from the pulpit, in specific terms. Not generalities. Say the names of the institutions that failed. Say the patterns by which they failed. Say that those failures are the reason some of the congregation's children

Second, build concrete accountability into the congregation. Background checks on everyone in children's and youth ministry. Two-adult rules without exception. A credible process for reporting concerns that does not route through the pastor who might be the problem. A standing relationship with outside, trauma-informed counselors. A written policy on how allegations will be handled, biased toward believing the vulnerable and committed to involving civil authorities in any suspected crime. A willingness to share information with other congregations when a leader leaves under concerning circumstances, rather than wrapping the departure in confidentiality. These structures are not signs of cynicism. They are signs of humility — the institution admitting it cannot trust itself, and therefore building systems that do not depend on the goodness of any one person.

Third, develop a pastoral theology of trauma adequate to what the victim carries. She does not need to be told to pray harder. She needs a trauma-informed therapist she can actually afford. She needs a congregation that can sit with her through the slow work of healing, without timelines, without pressure to produce the expected breakthroughs. She needs the church to say, we were part of the system that hurt you, even if neither of us was the specific actor, and we are sorry. She needs permission to have a complicated relationship with prayer, with worship, with Scripture, for as long as that complexity takes. She

Fourth, do not defend the indefensible. When a major evangelical figure falls, and the fall is confirmed, do not construct elaborate reasons why his teaching can still be relied on. Do not suggest his accusers had political motives. Do not deflect to the sins of progressive Christians as if the comparison excused the failure. Confess it. Say it cost the church dearly. Say the institution's response fell short and say what must change — even at the cost of friendships with pastors still in the defensive crouch. The young person is listening. The single word that restores her faith may be a willingness to say something true about a man who shook the pastor's hand at the conference last year.

Fifth, teach a doctrine of authority that does not place pastors or elders beyond challenge. The New Testament model of eldership is plural, accountable, and servant-shaped, not monarchical. Paul expected elders to be corrected. Peter was rebuked to his face. The congregation was not passive material for the leaders to shape; it was a body that carried the Spirit and was capable, under the Spirit, of discerning when its leaders had gone wrong. Restoring this is no concession to modern egalitarianism. It is a return to what the New Testament actually teaches, and it is the structural precondition for any church that will not repeat the abuses it confesses.

TO THE ONE WHO WAS HARMED

The silence that surrounded the wrongness was a second injury. The institution that failed to protect the victim failed the God it claimed to serve, not the other way around. The victim's faith, or what remains of it, is not on trial here. The institution is. To have left the church because one could not stay inside the institution that did the harm is not failure. It is accurate observation of the world that was presented. There are Christians, and Christian communities, doing the slow work of not being like the institution that did the harm. Some are trustworthy. Some are not yet. Trust slowly. Trust specifically. Trust people, not logos. The grief carried out of that room is not a sign of failed faith. It is a sign that what happened mattered, that the victim refuses to pretend it did not, and that the God she may or may not still believe in holds the same posture toward it. He is not pleased. He is not on the side of the institution. He grieves what she grieves.

THE WORK THAT WILL HOLD

A word, too, for the pastor who is no victim but who lives close to the culture that produces abuse. Examine the habits. Is there a personality cult running without its leader's knowledge? Are there people afraid to disagree? Does the staff meeting hold any real disagreement, or has disagreement been punished until it quietly disappeared? Are the accountability relationships actually accountable,

The abusive pastor is rarely a monster who entered ministry to hurt people. He is, in most cases, a man who began with real conviction and then, over decades, let the small compromises of power accumulate, unchallenged, until the compromises were the whole person. No one is immune. The guardrails are the point. Install them. Trust them. Let them do their work.

The reckoning is not over. It is not close to over. The investigations that reshaped the Southern Baptist Convention will reshape other networks in the coming decade, because the pattern is not unique to the SBC; it is unique to institutions run by men with power. The church that wants to be trustworthy again must face what is coming, confess what is surfacing, protect the vulnerable without exception, and accept that its credibility will be rebuilt over a generation, not a news cycle. The work is possible. It is not comfortable. It is what the faith itself calls for, and it is what the young person who watched the failures is waiting to see. Not more statements. Not more branding. Structural change, sustained through the slow years, visible in the policies, verifiable in the practice. That is the work. It is the only work that will hold.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Doubt as Devotion

The deconstruction wave has made one contribution to American Christian life worth naming as a gift rather than a threat. It has forced the church to speak about doubt in a way the church has mostly refused to. For a generation, evangelical preaching treated doubt as a problem to be solved, a weakness to be confessed, a symptom of a life not fully surrendered. The doubters sat in the pews and listened to sermons about the doubters as though the doubters were some other, outside population. They learned to hide. They learned to say amen when they did not feel amen, to sing songs of confident faith they did not have, to perform belief in order to remain acceptable. The performance was never going to hold. When it broke, the breaking looked like apostasy. It was not apostasy. It was the end of the performance.

Doubt, rightly understood, is not the opposite of faith. It is often the form faith takes in a mind that is thinking. Scripture gives this to us repeatedly, for anyone with the eyes to see it. The psalms of lament are doubt made

THE PRAYER BOOK OF THE PEOPLE OF GOD

The psalms are where the church has the most room to recover the theology of doubt it lost. The book of Psalms is the prayer book of the people of God. It was the prayer book of Jesus. At a conservative estimate it is one-third complaint and one-third lament. The singers of these psalms are not theological novices or weak faith or people in need of correction by some confident senior saint. They are the core of the worshiping tradition, and the core of the worshiping tradition spent a great portion of its praying life in complaint.

How long, O Lord? Will you forget me forever? How long will you hide your face from me?

— PSALM 13:1

That is not a warm-up to the real faith. That is the faith. The psalmist does faith by speaking this complaint to the God he does not, at the moment, feel is listening. The faith is not located in the feeling. It is located in the act of

A church that cannot pray Psalm 13 without editing it has not understood the faith it claims to have inherited. A church that skips the laments in its services, or softens them into generic confessions of struggle, has taken from its people the one prayer language they need most when they need any prayer at all. The deconstructor who was told to stop doubting and start trusting was handed advice the psalmist would not recognize. The psalmist trusts by doubting out loud in the presence of the One he doubts. That is the model. Lose the model, and the people no longer know how to stay in relationship with God through the dark seasons, because no one ever taught them that the relationship includes the dark.

THE QUESTIONS SCRIPTURE REFUSES TO RESOLVE

Habakkuk goes further. The prophet opens with a complaint that God is doing nothing about the injustice in Judah. God answers, eventually, that he will indeed do something: he will bring the Babylonians to sack the country. Habakkuk's response is a second complaint, longer and more specific than the first. You will use the Babylonians to discipline us, but the Babylonians are worse than we are. How can the Holy One use the unholy as his instrument? The prophet holds that question, unresolved, through much of the book.

God's answer is not a refutation of the question. It is a promise that the righteous will live by faith, and a vision in which God's character is shown to be worth trusting even



*Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be
on the vines, the produce of the olive fail and the
fields yield no food, yet I will rejoice in the Lord.*

– HABAKKUK 3:17-18

That is not the resolution of the question. It is a decision, made inside the unresolved question, to keep trusting the character of the God whose ways remain a mystery. The question is never answered. The prophet is answered. This is what mature faith often looks like in Scripture. Not faith without questions. Faith inside the questions, making its decisions about trust on the basis of the God it already knows from the long history of God's dealings, even when the present dealing makes no sense. The deconstructor told that faith requires the absence of questions has been handed a simulation of faith, not the thing itself. The thing itself is more rugged. It survives hard questions because it was built for them.

Job is the same case carried into the courtroom. Thirty-seven chapters of dialogue between Job and his comforters, who defend a theological system Job will not accept. He will not accept it because it does not match his experience, and because it asks him to confess sins he did not commit in order to rescue God's reputation. Job declines the rescue. At the end God vindicates him against the comforters: they have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has. Consider it. The comforters held the doctrinally correct theology of retribution, that suffering follows sin. Job rejected it. God sided with Job. The lesson is not that Job was sophisticated; he admits he

*God prefers the honest complaint that
refuses to explain him to the dishonest
piety that protects a system at the cost
of the truth.*

The contemporary American evangelical church is full of comforters. It is full of people who will assure the doubter that God has a plan, that everything will work out, that the suffering is building character, that the doubter simply needs to trust. These comforters are not always wrong. Sometimes they are right. But when they are right, they are right by accident, because the method is wrong. The method is to defend God's reputation by explaining God's ways, and the book of Job is on record that this is exactly the method that offends him. God does not need defending by explanations the doubter experiences as lies. He prefers, Job says, the truthful complaint that leaves the question open.

TELLING THE HONEST DOUBT FROM THE EVASIVE ONE

Not every expression of doubt is automatically legitimate faith. Some doubt is intellectual laziness. Some is a mask

The test is not primarily doctrinal. It is postural. The doubter who is seeking truth keeps showing up, keeps asking, keeps reading, keeps praying in the half-light. The doubter who is avoiding truth stops showing up, stops asking, stops reading, stops praying, and reaches instead for the lifestyle the doubt has opened. Both may use the same vocabulary of deconstruction. They are, in fact, two different phenomena. The first is faith in process. The second is something else. A good pastor watches which one is in front of him and responds accordingly. The first needs companionship. The second needs a loving confrontation.

THE DARK NIGHT HAS A NAME

The category of the dark night of the soul has entered Christian conversation with less precision than it deserves. The term comes from the sixteenth-century Spanish mystic John of the Cross, who described a specific experience in which God, he argued, withdraws the emotional consolations of faith in order to purify the believer's attachment. The dark night is not the same as doubt, though from the inside it can look like it. It is an

The mystics who wrote about it — John of the Cross, Teresa of Avila, Thomas Merton — insisted that this condition, unpleasant as it is, is often a sign of progress rather than regression. The believer is being weaned from reliance on the emotional by-products of faith so that she can come to rest in the God who is there even when the by-products are gone. This is a gift the church can give a certain kind of deconstructor. The person who says, I used to feel God's presence and now I feel nothing, so I must have lost the faith, is often the person who is, in fact, in a dark night. The felt presence was never the faith. It was a gracious support God gives new believers and sometimes takes from maturing ones. Its absence does not indicate the absence of God. It can indicate a deepening of the relationship, now asked to grow up into something less dependent on felt reassurance.

Mother Teresa lived most of her adult life in this condition. The letters published after her death show a woman who worked among the dying in Calcutta for five decades while feeling nothing whatsoever of the God she served. Her superiors, when she confided it, affirmed her: the condition was consistent with her calling, and the service itself was the faith. She continued. The continuation was the faith. This is not a fringe topic. It is mainstream Christian spirituality, attested across centuries and traditions and individual lives that bear the marks of deep faith. Teach it. Name it. Let the congregation know that the felt absence of God, inside a continuing commitment to God, is not a sign of failure but one of the ways mature faith can look. The deconstructor

A THEOLOGY OF DOUBT

Set out as a positive proposal rather than only a corrective, a theology of doubt begins with the recognition that God is greater than the mind's capacity to comprehend him. This is not evasion. It is one of the oldest confessions of the tradition. God is not an object in the universe, available for inventory the way a chair or a planet is. He is the ground of being, the source from which all finite things come, the mystery at the center of existence. Talk about God is always partial, always analogical, always bounded by the limits of the creaturely mind attempting it. Doubt, honestly faced, is often the creaturely mind meeting its limits and being rightly humbled by them. That encounter is closer to worship than to apostasy.

It continues with the recognition that Scripture itself carries the doubting voices and honors them. Job. Ecclesiastes. The laments. The anger of Jeremiah, who accused God of seducing him. The confused silence of the disciples after the crucifixion. The cry of dereliction from the cross itself:

■ *My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?*

— MARK 15:34

This is not decoration on the Bible. It is the center of it. The center of the Christian faith is a moment of the Son putting to the Father a question the text never answers. The answer is not given. The answer is embodied, three days later, in the resurrection. But the question stands.

Finally, a theology of doubt grounds itself in the person of Jesus Christ. The doubter is not asked to believe a system. The doubter is asked to keep looking at Jesus in the Gospels and to say what he actually sees. If Jesus, after a long look, still compels, then the doubter still has a faith, even when every doctrinal position he once held is now in motion. Faith in Christ is more durable than faith in the system that interpreted Christ. The system has often been wrong. Christ remains. The doubter who has lost confidence in the system and still cannot stop looking at Christ is not a failed believer. He is, in some ways, more clearly a believer than many who hold the system with confidence but have not looked at Christ in years.

WHAT THE PASTOR DOES WITH THIS

First, preach the doubting Scriptures. Give a sermon series to the psalms of lament. Preach through Job, not only the punchline at the end but the whole architecture of the dialogue. Preach Habakkuk. Preach the cry of dereliction. Let the congregation hear, from the pulpit, that the faith they inherited has always included these voices, and that the voices are part of the faith, not a departure from it.

Second, make space for expressed doubt. Hold conversations in small groups structured around the questions rather than around the approved answers. Train lay leaders to host those conversations without defensiveness. Let the doubter discover, in a Christian

Third, do not rush the resolution. The doubter is on a schedule that is not the pastor's. Some questions take decades to settle, and some are never settled on this side. The faithful posture toward the doubter is patience. The church that expected every question to resolve by next Tuesday has failed many doubters. The church that can walk with one for five years without pressuring resolution has a chance of keeping her.

Fourth, model honest doubt, within limits. The pastor who pretends never to have doubted anything is not credible and imitates no saint in church history. The pastor who shares with discernment from his own seasons of aridity and unresolved question gives the congregation permission to have the same. The sharing has to be careful; the pulpit is not the place to process a current crisis. But the pulpit is the place to tell the congregation, truthfully, that faith has seasons, that some of them are dark, and that the God who met his people in the dark is the God they continue to trust even when they do not feel him.

Fifth, tell the doubter out loud that her continued place in the congregation does not depend on arriving at specific conclusions by specific dates. Tell her she is honored by her presence whether her questions ever fully resolve or not. Tell her the church is not a fraternity requiring agreement on a password. It is a family that loves its members through whatever they are carrying. This telling alone can keep her for years. The lack of it will, predictably, lose her.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Reconstruction

One word has swallowed the conversation, and the other has barely found its footing. Deconstruction is everywhere; reconstruction is an afterthought. That is a problem, because deconstruction on its own is a half-process. To pull something apart without knowing how to build anything is not arrival. It is a stalled engine. Much of the deconstruction wave has stalled exactly there — not because the people in it lacked the will to move, but because the only map they were handed described the demolition and nothing past it. What does faith look like on the far side? The answer differs from person to person, and it asks something of the reader: courage.

Not every deconstruction ends the same way. Some who deconstruct become atheists or agnostics, having concluded that the supernatural frame does not survive scrutiny, and they build lives inside a secular one they find sufficient. Some land in a spiritual-but-not-religious drift, keeping vague convictions about meaning and the transcendent while holding no ecclesial home —

RECOVERING THE GREAT TRADITION

The first piece is the recovery of the Great Tradition — the broad stream of Christian thought and practice that predates the modern period and forms the shared inheritance of Catholics, Orthodox, and historic Protestants. The Apostles' Creed. The Nicene Creed. The seven ecumenical councils. The liturgical year. The sacraments. The disciplines of prayer, fasting, silence, and Scripture meditation the church has kept, in one form or another, since its earliest centuries.

Many American evangelical deconstructors were never introduced to any of it. They assume American evangelicalism is Christianity, so that in rejecting the one they have rejected the whole. The assumption is historically ignorant. American evangelicalism in its present shape is a recent cultural formation — two hundred years old at its roots, only a few decades old in its current form. The Great Tradition is two thousand years

So begin by reading it. Augustine's Confessions. Athanasius on the incarnation. Julian of Norwich. Bonaventure. Thomas Aquinas, at least in summary. The Philokalia from the Orthodox stream. Thomas à Kempis. George Herbert. Bonhoeffer. Marilynne Robinson. These are not extras. They are the spine of the faith one may have thought he left, and they are still here, patient, waiting to be noticed. Read them and a discovery often follows: many of the questions that made evangelicalism unsupportable are not questions these writers share. They lived inside a faith with different loads on it, different emphases, different habits. Their Christianity is continuous with the reader's and not identical to the one that exhausted him. That discovery alone can reopen the possibility of faith.

RECOVERING PRACTICE

The second piece is the recovery of practice. Over the last century American evangelicalism has tended to reduce the Christian life to belief plus affect: hold the right propositions, feel the right emotions about Jesus. The reduction has left generations without a practice that can hold them when the beliefs get complicated and the feelings dry up.

The Great Tradition has always held faith together with practice. You pray the daily office. You fast on appointed

The deconstructor looking for something that will hold her does not need, first, a better apologetic. She needs a practice. She needs a trustworthy director or pastor or friend to hand her a short list and say: do these, for a year, without worrying whether you believe them. Pray the Lord's Prayer every morning. Read one psalm a day. Take communion weekly if a church will let you, even when you are unsure of everything around it. Keep a Sabbath. Give a tenth of your income to causes you respect. Volunteer, consistently, at one institution that serves the vulnerable in your city. Confess your real sins — not the generic ones — to one trusted human being. Sustained, these practices change the person doing them, and over time they do something to the beliefs that sit above them. The beliefs clarify. Some fall away. Some deepen. The process will not keep the timeline of the person's impatience. It keeps the timeline of the practice. This is how the faith has worked for most of its history, and recovering it means recovering something nearly everyone in modern Christianity has lost.

RECOVERING COMMUNITY AND INTELLECT

The third piece is the recovery of a communal frame. Christianity is not a private enterprise. It has always been,

This is hard. The community he came from is often the very thing he is still processing. The alternatives look off-putting — too conservative or too progressive, too formal or too casual. Walking into an unfamiliar tradition is uncomfortable. It is necessary anyway. No one reconstructs the faith alone in his kitchen. It takes other bodies in a room, praying and singing and serving alongside, over years, until the practice becomes the person.

The community you find does not have to be the one you end in. Many on this path passed through several congregations before they settled. The deconstructor who tries an Anglican parish, finds it useful for a season, then sits through a Catholic mass and finds it more than she expected, then lands in a liturgical Lutheran congregation that fits her, has not been unstable. She has been searching with discernment, and discernment takes time. The only real mistake is quitting. Whoever tries one church, finds it imperfect, and concludes that church is not for him has simply not been patient. Every church is imperfect. The question is not whether the imperfection exists but whether the community, taken whole, is one in which a reconstruction can proceed. Stay when staying is productive. Leave when leaving is necessary. Do not confuse discomfort with incompatibility. Much of this work is sitting through discomfort.

The fourth piece is the recovery of an intellectual architecture equal to the actual weight of the questions.

To widen it, read outside the subset. The Catholic philosophers — Alasdair MacIntyre, Charles Taylor, James K. A. Smith. The Orthodox theologians — John Zizioulas, David Bentley Hart, Frederica Mathewes-Green. The mainline Protestant heavyweights — Karl Barth, Dietrich Bonhoeffer, Stanley Hauerwas, Fleming Rutledge. The contemporary evangelicals doing serious intellectual work — N. T. Wright, Richard Hays, Miroslav Volf, Esau McCaulley. They do not all agree, and the reader will not agree with all of them, but they supply categories the thin toolkit never offered. They show that the faith is more durable, more interesting, and more able to bear intellectual weight than the evangelicalism he left ever admitted.

RECOVERING TIME, SUFFERING, AND OBEDIENCE

The fifth piece is the recovery of a long view of time. Because it is young, American evangelicalism keeps a short memory. It speaks of the early church and has the creeds at hand, but its felt horizon is the last forty years. Something is judged successful when the pastor's podcast grows. Something is judged true when the contemporary consensus affirms it.

That short horizon makes the tradition feel less stable

The sixth piece is the recovery of suffering as a category of Christian experience that is not, first of all, a problem to be solved. The evangelical frame often treats suffering as an anomaly: why would a good God let this happen? The Great Tradition treats it as central. The cross stands at the heart of the faith. The martyrs are named each year on the calendar. The monastic life is built around the recognition that the Christian life is, in significant part, a willing entry into the suffering of Christ. The deconstructor who was told that suffering is a problem the faith exists to solve was handed a version the actual tradition does not hold. The tradition holds that suffering is real, that it is entered rather than avoided, that God is present in it rather than explaining it away, and that the resurrection is the final word — but that the cross is the precondition of the resurrection. That reframing can save a person who has been straining to hold a Christianity that pretended the cross was optional.

The seventh piece, and the one many find hardest, is the recovery of obedience. Somewhere in deconstruction,

*The yes that says: I have looked at the
teachings of Jesus, and at the
alternatives my culture offers, and I
would rather live inside his teachings,
with all their cost, than inside the
alternatives, with all of theirs.*

That yes, chosen freely, against the grain of the surrounding culture, is what the church in every age has meant by faith. The deconstructor who reaches it has not returned to the starting point. She has arrived at something the starting point could never have produced, because the starting point had not yet been tested.

WHAT THE CHURCH OWES THE RECONSTRUCTOR

A word about the timeline. This is a long process. It is not the six-week course a church sometimes offers to bring

And a word about what the church owes the reconstructor, as distinct from the deconstructor. The deconstructor needs space, acknowledgment, and patience. The reconstructor, the one building on the other side, needs more active resources. She needs reading recommendations. She needs a mentor. She needs a liturgy and a practice and a community that can carry the weight of the faith she is trying to rebuild. She needs the pastor who will meet her once a month for a year to talk through what she is reading. She needs the church that will let her participate before the reconstruction is finished. These things cost the church time, money, patience, and a willingness to host an incomplete faith. A church that cannot pay these costs will not help her. A church that will pay them gains a member whose faith, when it finally lands, is more robust and more contagious than the faith of many who have been there all their lives.

End with a single image. A woman who went through a long and painful deconstruction after spiritual abuse in her childhood church said that what finally held her was not one conversation or one book. It was a small Anglican parish that let her sit in the back during compline every Sunday night for two years before she spoke a word to

The church that can cultivate this shape has a future.
The church that cannot, does not.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Church We Could Still Become

Fifteen chapters have named what went wrong and what an honest answer to it requires. What remains is to describe the congregation that could result — one that took the diagnosis seriously and built its common life around the response. This is not a utopia, and it is not a model that fits every context. It is a composite sketch, drawn from congregations worth visiting, pastors worth learning from, and the imperfect work of churches that have been at it for years. The sketch is encouragement, not prescription. Take what is useful. Leave what is not. Build what the people in front of you need.

A CHURCH THAT TELLS THE TRUTH ABOUT ITSELF

The first mark of the church we could still become is that it tells the truth about itself. It does not perform. It does not brand. It does not stage an emotional experience to be

It names the failures, and it names them specifically. The abuse cover-ups. The political captivity. The financial scandals. The purity culture that wounded a generation. A doctrine of hell preached more vividly than the love of Christ. The flag in the sanctuary. It names these not as rhetorical throat-clearing but as the actual conditions under which it is attempting to rebuild.

Truth-telling of this kind is not a single confession. It is a culture — the way the pastor speaks every week, the way the elders operate, the way the members are trained to talk about their own church. The young adult who comes back for the first Sunday in six years, hesitant, half-expecting the old evasions, hears the pulpit say something true about Ravi Zacharias, or the Southern Baptist report, or the last election, and feels something she has not felt in a sanctuary in a long time. She feels that the pulpit is standing in the same world she is. That feeling will do more than every outreach campaign the church has ever run.

A CHURCH WITH STRUCTURES, NOT SLOGANS

The second mark is structural accountability. A church that has told the truth has, by that telling, exposed itself to a question: how will it keep the failures from recurring?

Such a church publishes how allegations of misconduct will be handled, and the procedure does not route through the accused; it routes through an independent party, external to the staff and the eldership, whose task is to investigate. It runs background checks on everyone in children's and youth ministry. It enforces a two-adult rule, with consequences for violation. It sets a conflict-of-interest policy covering the pastor's compensation, travel, and outside income. It places term limits on elders so that no single faction becomes entrenched. It submits its finances to outside review every year. It names an ombudsperson to whom any member can carry a concern without first passing it through the person the concern is about.

None of this is exotic. It is ordinary, and it costs nothing but humility. The refusal to adopt it is itself a confession of what a church actually values.

A CHURCH WITH LITURGICAL DEPTH

The third mark is liturgical depth. The church that has been running a ninety-minute production will have to learn, again, to worship — worship in the older sense. The congregation gathers. It confesses its sins aloud and together, in words Christians have prayed for centuries. It hears the Word read in several passages, not only the one the sermon will mine. It says the Creed. It sings the songs of the last five years, but not only those; it sings the hymns that carried the faith across generations. It prays the Lord's Prayer in one voice. It comes to the Table more

It keeps the calendar — Advent, Christmas, Epiphany, Lent, Easter, Pentecost, Ordinary Time — not because the calendar is magic, but because it gives the year a shape not dictated by the retail season or the sports schedule. The year takes its form from the story of Christ, and the congregation learns, without quite noticing the lesson, that the story of Christ is the story it lives inside.

Many American evangelicals received a worship that carefully removed these elements, on the unspoken theory that they were Catholic, or high church, or dead religion. They are none of those things. They are the worship of the church across two thousand years. The contemporary service that stripped them out is the innovation; the elements are the tradition. Restoring them is not a retreat into formality at the expense of life. It is a recovery of the forms that have, in every age, proved able to carry the faith through upheaval. The years ahead will demand worship that can carry weight. The praise band and the teachable moment are lighter forms than what is coming will require.

A CHURCH THAT TEACHES THE FAITH

The fourth mark is catechesis — a word most evangelicals have not spoken in a hundred years, meaning simply the structured teaching of the faith to people who want to learn it. The American evangelical church largely assumed faith would be absorbed by osmosis, from services and youth groups and small groups and family devotions. The assumption did not hold.

The generation raised in evangelical households absorbed something, but it was not the faith. It was a set of cultural markers, a handful of verses, a reflex of partisan

It writes a catechism, or adopts a historic one, or works through a classic like the Heidelberg or Luther's Small Catechism. It asks every new member, whatever their age, to spend a year inside it before joining. It does the same with its teenagers, so that the confirmation class becomes not a rite of passage but a year of serious engagement with the historic faith — the creeds, the sacraments, the Lord's Prayer, the Ten Commandments, the Beatitudes, the central doctrines, and the practices that have sustained Christians through hard times. The graduates are not certified theologians. They are formed in a way most American evangelicals never were, and they will be able to hold, under pressure, what a thinner formation would have let slip.

A CHURCH WITH A REAL THEOLOGY OF SUFFERING

The fifth mark is a real theology of suffering. A church that teaches one will, by the same curriculum, disarm the prosperity reflex that has crept into every corner of American Christianity, including the corners that would reject the prosperity gospel by name. The reflex assumes that if a person is faithful, things will work out. That assumption is not biblical. It is American.

Preaching it out, week by week, over years, will cost the preacher something. The congregation will not love, at first, the sermons that tell the truth about what the Christian life actually costs. The instruction is to stay with

Scripture never made the lighter promise. The man it calls a man of sorrows knew what it asked:

He was despised and rejected by men, a man of sorrows, and acquainted with grief.

— ISAIAH 53:3

A CHURCH THAT MAKES ROOM BEYOND THE NUCLEAR FAMILY

The sixth mark is a reimagined account of friendship, singleness, and family. For generations the American evangelical church has centered the nuclear family in a way that left single adults, divorced adults, childless adults, and adults whose families were in disarray on the margins of congregational life. The centering was done in the name of family values, and it left many Christians feeling they were not fully Christian unless they had the right kind of household.

The New Testament does not teach this. Jesus, Paul, and most of the early church's missionary leadership were single. The church was a family that exceeded biological family. It was where the childless woman found mothering to do, where the orphan found fathers and brothers, where the person with no blood kin found kin.

A congregation that recovers this builds durable practices of friendship. It hosts meals that bring single

A CHURCH UNAFRAID OF ITS OWN MIND

Such a church also takes the intellectual life of its members seriously. Its teaching ministry is more than a Sunday sermon. It runs reading groups and classes on the historic creeds and the great Christian thinkers. It hosts speakers who can meet serious questions about science, philosophy, ethics, and history. It keeps a library, physical or digital, that members actually use. From the pulpit it models the reading of serious books, and its pastor reads beyond the titles of his own subculture. Members know their hardest questions are welcome, that they will be answered with seriousness, and that no one will be looked at strangely for asking.

This is not intellectualism in the bad sense. It is not pretension, and it is not credentialing. It is a congregation that believes its faith is true, that the truth of the faith can bear scrutiny, that scrutiny is therefore welcome, and that the life of the mind belongs to the love of God with heart,

A CHURCH THAT NEITHER RETREATS NOR CONQUERS

The seventh mark is a posture toward the world that is neither retreat nor conquest. For a century the American evangelical church has oscillated between two unhealthy stances. The first is retreat: circling the wagons, treating the broader culture as the enemy, raising children inside a bubble in the hope of keeping them uncontaminated. The second is conquest: seeing the culture as territory to be taken, building political campaigns and media empires to take it, and measuring faithfulness by the power accumulated.

Neither is the posture of Christ. He was no monastic and no political operative. He was a rabbi who walked into the villages, sat at the tables of the unrighteous, told the truth, suffered for it, and rose from the dead. His followers have been most faithful when they lived as residents of the kingdom of God inside the kingdom of this world — neither fleeing it nor seeking to rule it, present in it as witnesses, servants, friends, neighbors, and when necessary, martyrs.

The congregation that recovers this is engaged with its city, its schools, its social wounds, its homeless and addicted and abused and bereaved — not to win, not to look good, not to run a program, but because its Lord is

*The congregation that can absorb the
hatred of every tribe and still love the
enemies who send it is recognizably
the church of Jesus Christ. The
congregation adopted by one tribe and
cheered by it is something else,
whatever it calls itself.*

A CHURCH WITH GENERATIONAL PATIENCE

The eighth mark is generational patience. The church we could become does not expect to reverse the cultural slide in five years. It does not expect all its children to return. It does not expect its community to notice its faithfulness. It is playing a long game it may lose, in its current institutional form, within its own lifetime — and it is content to lose that game, because it knows the game it is actually playing is not scored on those stakes.

Say it plainly. The churches that survive the next forty years in anything like a recognizable Christian form will not be the ones that ran the largest conferences, produced the most popular podcasts, or held the most political power at their peak. They will be the ones that did the quiet, unglamorous work — present to the people in their neighborhoods, teaching the faith carefully to the children in their care, keeping prayer and sacrament with patience across years, telling the truth about their failures, and trusting God with the rest. Many are small. Many are obscure. Many will never be written about. They exist, and they are, right now, the seed crystal from which Christianity in this country will, if it continues, continue.

A CHURCH THAT LOVES THE ONES WHO LEFT

The ninth mark is love for the people who have left — the one the church has forgotten and the one the deconstructor most needs to hear. The church we could become does not write them off. It does not file them under apostate or cautionary tale. It does not speak of them as lost causes or as enemies. It holds them. It prays for them by name. It welcomes them back, whenever and if

The deconstructor reading this may be thinking: there has never been a church like the one described here. Two things are worth saying. First, this church exists in fragments and approximations, in scattered places, and it is possible to find one. Try again. Not every church is the church that was left. Second, where it cannot be found, it can be built. The person who walked away from a broken institution because it was broken is under no obligation to return to a broken institution. That person is, however, available — as a member of a body of Christ that has not ceased to exist — to help some local congregation become the thing it should have been all along.

The shortage of trustworthy churches will not fix itself. It will be repaired, if it is repaired, by people who have seen what is wrong and who carry the conviction, the pain, and the residual faith to help build the alternative. To such a person the church says: it has not treated you well, and it is asking anyway whether you will come back — not to the institution that hurt you, but to the Lord who has not stopped loving you — and whether, as part of that return, you will lend a hand to the slow work of making the next version of the institution less hurtful and more faithful.

This is the church we could still become. It is not a church of the future. It is a church that, in scattered forms, has always existed in the history of the Christian people, and that is laboring to be born again in this generation, in the aftermath of a collapse that was, in many ways, the

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Parents of Deconstructors

You are the largest group of readers this book has, and the one most often left out of the conversation — present only as a cautionary tale or a sympathy case. You are neither. You are, in many instances, a person of deep faith carrying a grief that has no obvious vocabulary and no clear resolution. You did what you knew to do. You took the children to church. You did the devotions. You prayed the prayers. You paid for the Christian school, or modeled the family altar, or led the youth group, or hosted the small group. You watched your child grow up, profess faith, maybe even get baptized — and then, in high school or in college or in the first hard year after it, walk away.

The child is not always angry. Sometimes the child is kind. The child still calls, still shows up at Christmas, simply does not believe anymore, or does not believe the way you believe. And you are left holding a question with no answer you can accept. What did I do wrong. What

The grief is always the same and the specifics are always different, because every family is its own country with its own history, and the specifics matter. What follows is counsel meant to help you stand inside this situation without breaking.

YOUR CHILD'S DECONSTRUCTION IS NOT A VERDICT ON YOU

In most cases it is not the indictment of your parenting you are reading it as. You read it that way because evangelical culture trained you to. It taught you that if you did your job, the child would walk with the Lord. It taught you that one verse was a guarantee:

*Train up a child in the way he should go, and when
he is old he will not depart from it.*

— PROVERBS 22:6

That verse is a general principle about how character is formed, not a promise that faithful parenting secures a child's faith. The teaching that made it a promise was Americanized pragmatism dressed in biblical language — the prosperity gospel applied to the family, where the right inputs are owed the right outputs. The actual biblical picture is more complicated and far less reassuring. It includes Samuel, whose sons were corrupt. David, whose sons were corrupt. Eli, whose sons were corrupt. Hosea, whose marriage God made a parable for Israel's unfaithfulness. It includes God himself, in the prophets' accounting — the parent who raised children only to watch them turn against him. When the pattern runs through the

You are not Samuel. You are not David. You are also not, thank God, required to be. You are a parent who did your best inside your limits, and whose child, being an adult, is making her own decisions. Those decisions do not belong to you. They never were going to. The notion that you could guarantee her faith by the quality of your parenting was a fantasy, and the guilt it has been manufacturing in you is not from the Lord. He has a long record of working patiently with people whose parents were terrible and whose children were worse. He is working patiently with yours. Let him.

THE RELATIONSHIP OUTWEIGHS THE POSITION

Your relationship with your child matters more than her current theology. That can sound like the kind of thing said to soften your conviction. It is not. The thing you have, and can maintain, and can build on, is the relationship. The thing you cannot control, and must not try to manage, is her belief. Spend your energy on the first. Save your theological energy for your own spiritual life, for your pastor, for your small group.

Do not bring the theology to the dinner table unless she brings it first. Do not preface every phone call with a quiet check on her spiritual temperature. Do not send the articles you have been saving. Do not forward the podcast episode. She knows where you stand; you have told her with your life. She is not failing to become a Christian for lack of information. She has plenty. She is working

This is harder than it sounds. You will sit through Thanksgiving dinners while the child's new boyfriend says things about religion you know to be false, and you will bite your tongue. You will hear, from your own child, criticisms of the church you have loved for fifty years, and in some cases you will have to agree with them, even when the agreement costs you. You will welcome her home without treating her like a project, without the scheduled pointed conversation, without introducing the visiting pastor with a meaningful look. Every instinct you were trained in will pull the other way. Resist every one of them, out of love for the person in front of you, who is your child and not a theological case study.

Adjust the clock while you are at it. The years may be longer than you are used to imagining. Deconstruction takes time, and for your child the timeline may be five years, or ten, or twenty. If you have been quietly assuming this is a phase that passes by next Christmas, you will not make it through with your soul intact. You will burn out on hope, then burn out on despair, then settle into a low-grade resentment that poisons everything.

Reset the internal clock to the real timeline. Say it plainly: I am in this for the next twenty years. Then ask the better question — what does faithful love look like over twenty years? The parent who can ask that stops grasping at each conversation for the sign the child is turning. She has released the demand. She keeps loving, keeps praying, keeps offering the relationship, and waits.

At various points you will be tempted to give up on prayer. The prayers have not worked. The child is further from the faith than five years ago. Why keep going. The temptation is understandable and should be resisted. Keep praying — and change what you pray for.

You have probably been praying, for years, some version of: Lord, bring her back to faith. That prayer is not wrong, but it is a prayer about a single distant outcome, and it wears you down when the outcome does not arrive on your schedule. Pray instead the prayers you can watch being answered in real time. Pray for her protection today. Pray for a kind person in her life today. Pray that she feels loved today, by you and by whoever else is in her orbit. Pray that God will be present to her in whatever way she can receive him today. These are answered, most days, in small ways you will not always see but can trust. They keep the line open. They form you into a person practicing trust in what you cannot see rather than demanding evidence you cannot produce. And over years they soften your own heart in ways the relationship needs. The child who comes home for a weekend and finds a parent softer than she expected is the child who may, in time, bring more of herself back into the conversation.

DO NOT CARRY IT ALONE

You will often feel ashamed in church, and the church has often been the source of the shame even when it never intended to be. You sit through sermons on raising children in the fear of the Lord and feel like a fraud. You

Find a community — inside your church or outside it — where you can be honest about what you are carrying. It may be one other couple. It may be a small group of parents in the same situation. It may be a counselor who understands the particular grief. It may be, if your own church cannot hold it, a different church. The enemy of your soul during this stretch is isolation. Resist it at every cost.

*Your job is to love her. God's job is to
save her. The whole of your peace
depends on not mixing up the jobs.*

If you are married, the deconstruction of a child will test the marriage in ways you did not anticipate. You and your spouse will grieve on different timelines. One of you will want to talk about it more, the other less. One will see signs of hope, the other signs of loss. One will blame himself, and the other, in a weak moment, will blame him. Marriages have ended over this. Do not let yours be one of them. Put the marriage first. Go to counseling if you need it. Agree, out loud, that neither of you will weaponize the child's situation against the other. Make the marriage a safe place for both of you to grieve honestly without making it worse. The children are watching, including the

WHEN THE CHILD HAS REJECTED YOU

Consider, specifically, the parent whose child has rejected not only the theology but the parent. This is the hardest case. The child has decided you were part of the problem. In some cases she has gone no-contact or low-contact. She is telling other people a story about your faith-shaped parenting that you, from inside it, do not recognize. This is grief compounded by powerlessness, and there is no formula. There are only a few things worth saying.

Examine the story she is telling as though it came from a stranger. Some of it may be more accurate than you can currently admit. The reflex to defend yourself is understandable and counterproductive. Where the story is true, acknowledge it, even if the acknowledgment is not invited. A letter, sent with no demand for response — I have been thinking about some things you said, and you were right about some of them, here is what I see, I am sorry — can do more than you expect. Do not expect it to work quickly. Do not expect it to work at all. Write it anyway, because it is true.

Where the story is not accurate, stay silent for now. Defending yourself to someone not ready to hear the defense only hardens the position. Time, kindness, consistent presence from a distance, and the Spirit do work that argument cannot. Trust that work.

There is a version of this chapter built around tactics — what to say, what not to say, how to handle Christmas, how to answer the social media post that horrifies you. The tactics follow from the posture, and the posture is the thing that is hard. The parent with the right posture will figure out the tactics. The parent without it will not, no matter how many tactics she reads.

The posture is this. Your child is a person. Her relationship with God is not yours to guarantee. Your love for her is unconditional and uncoerced. Your hope is in a God who is patient beyond your patience. Your prayer is that he will do what you cannot. Your presence in her life is a gift given without expectation. Your own faith does not depend on hers, and your identity as a Christian is not contingent on her outcomes. Hold that posture. Build your life around it. The years will pass. You will not always see progress. Over time you will find the grief has become something closer to love, and the love something closer to peace, even in the uncertainty. That is what parenting looks like here, when it goes well. It is not the happy ending you were hoping for. It is a different kind of happy, closer to the peace of Christ — who was himself left by people he loved, and went on loving them anyway.

There is a woman, seventy-one years old, who lost her son to the deconstruction wave twenty years ago. He is now in his mid-forties. She has prayed for him every day of those twenty years and been careful never to badger him. She has welcomed him home, with his wife and their children, for every holiday, and spoken of the faith only when he asked. In the last several years she has watched him begin to ask about certain things, tentatively, around

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Pastors in the Aftermath

Every conversation about deconstruction is, at some point, a conversation about the pastor. Not the celebrity whose fall set the crisis in motion. The ordinary one. The pastor who did not cover up the abuse, did not run an empire, did not fly private, did not build a brand. The one who preaches three times a week, visits the hospital on Tuesdays, counsels the divorcing couple on Wednesdays, meets the deacons on Thursdays, and writes Sunday's sermon on Friday night because the week got away from him again. He is not the problem the deconstructors left. He is standing in the middle of the aftermath, trying to figure out what to do next. This chapter is for him.

What he is carrying, often without naming it, is a compound grief. There is the grief of loss, because he has watched members leave over the last decade, and some of them were people he loved, people he baptized, people whose children he dedicated, people he assumed he would

These griefs compound over years, and he does not talk about them, because he was trained not to. The training was mostly implicit. Nobody told him he could not name his own confusion. The culture of pastoral leadership simply modeled a confidence that left no room for it. He preaches faith. He preaches trust. He preaches the hope of the church, all while carrying, privately, the weight of what does not seem to be working. The weight shows up in his body. It shows up in his sleep. It shows up in his marriage, in ways his wife can see and he cannot.

So hear this clearly. The problem is real. The confusion is legitimate. The grief is not a sign of failure. It is a sign that you are paying attention. The pastor who carries no version of this grief right now is either so insulated he has not noticed the situation, or so hardened he has stopped feeling it. Neither condition is better than yours. You are awake. You are honest. Start there.

FEED THE INSTRUMENT

The first practical matter is your own theological formation. Many pastors, if they are honest, stopped

This is fixable. Read. Read past the preachers in your tribe. Read the people your deconstructing members are reading. Read Charles Taylor's *A Secular Age*, even if it takes a year. Read David Bentley Hart, even where you disagree. Read Marilynne Robinson. Read N. T. Wright's longer works, not the popular summaries. Read the early fathers, even in translation. One difficult book a quarter, and guard the time as you would a hospital visit, because it is one. Your mind is the instrument through which you serve the congregation. Stop feeding it and the instrument goes dull, and dull sermons are, at this moment in the church's life, a luxury nobody can afford.

PREACH HONESTLY

The second matter is how you preach. The deconstructors in your pew, the pre-deconstructors, and the parents of deconstructors are all listening for the same thing. They are listening for honesty. They are listening for a sign that you know the world they are living in, that you

Be specific about what that preaching looks like. It means, sometimes, giving the first third of the sermon to the objection rather than the answer. It means describing the deconstructor's experience in terms she would recognize, not terms that caricature it. It means saying, from the pulpit, I understand why someone would leave over this. That sentence, spoken honestly, does more for your credibility than a year of relatable introductions. The congregation that hears you take the objection seriously will trust you when you give the response. The congregation that hears you dismiss it will conclude you do not understand their world, and the conclusion will be correct.

*The hearing is the first ministry.
Everything else depends on it.*

THE COFFEE, NOT THE EXAM

The third matter is the pastoral conversation. Most pastors, on learning that a congregant is deconstructing,

Try a different approach. When you learn that a congregant is deconstructing, do nothing pastoral for a while. Pray. Let the information settle. Then, the next time you see her, ask her to get coffee. Set no agenda. Do not call it counseling. Over coffee, ask one question and listen. The question is this: what has been happening for you in the last year or two. That is the whole question. Everything she says in response is material you need. Listen without rebutting. Listen without planning your reply. Listen past the first answer and the second answer into the third, which is usually the real one. When the real answer comes, stay with it. Do not reach for the scriptural corrective. The corrective may come later, in another conversation, once she has had the experience of being heard by a representative of the institution she felt never heard her. The hearing is the first ministry. Everything else depends on it.

GRIEF, REFORM, AND YOUR OWN FAITH

The fourth matter is grief counseling, for you. You need someone to talk to about this. Your spouse is not the right person, not because she does not care, but because she carries her own version of the grief, and the last thing she needs is to be your therapist. A counselor, a spiritual director, or a peer group of pastors in the same situation is

The fifth matter is what you tell your congregation about the people who have left. The temptation is to say nothing, because saying something feels like airing dirty laundry. The result is a silence the remaining congregation fills with its own stories, which are usually worse than the truth. Better to name the reality, generally, without naming names. Something like this, from the pulpit, at the right time. Some of you have noticed that people you love are no longer here. You are right. People have left. Some left because we failed them, and we need to own that. Some left because they are working through questions that take time. Some left for reasons we do not know. What I want to say is that we pray for them, we hold the door open for them, and we do not speak of them as enemies or as projects. We love them. And I want to ask you to do something that may feel strange. Reach out to them. Not to invite them to an event. Not to share a link. To tell them you miss them, with no agenda attached. That is what this church does with the people it has lost. We do not drop them. We carry them.

That language, from the pulpit, does two things at once. It tells the remaining congregation how to treat the people who have left, and it tells them the pastor sees the situation clearly. Both messages are needed. Both, in most congregations, go unspoken.

The sixth matter is institutional reform. Suppose you have read the case for the church we could become and

The seventh matter is your own faith, and someone has to address it. You are a pastor in the aftermath of a crisis in which the institution you serve has been publicly discredited. That is not a comfortable place to stand. For some pastors it is a quietly corrosive one. The doubts you preach about on Sunday sometimes visit you on Monday. The questions the congregation asks are questions you have asked yourself. The books the deconstructors are reading are books that have given you pause. Some pastors know exactly what this describes. Others may come to know it later.

So hear this too. Your questions are legitimate. Your faith is not invalidated by them. The counsel this book has offered the deconstructing layperson applies, with adjustments, to you. Read widely. Practice the ancient disciplines. Find a spiritual director. Pray the psalms of lament. You are permitted, as a pastor, to hold a complicated faith. You are permitted to hold the questions inside the vocation rather than stepping outside it to hold them. Moses held questions. Jeremiah held questions. The

A MINISTRY OF HOLDING

One final note. Pastoral ministry has always been, in part, a ministry of holding. You hold the wedding and the funeral. You hold the sick and the confused. You hold the teenager who tried to kill herself and the widow who wants to follow her husband into death. You hold the angry deacon, the worn-out volunteer, the family falling apart, the child who was abused, the man who has been drinking again. The holding is not a technique. It is the vocation.

What this season of the church's life asks of you is to hold one more thing: the grief and the faith at once. The holding will not be resolved in your lifetime. The crisis will outlast your ministry. What you can do, inside your ministry, is hold it well. Hold it honestly. Hold it without pretending it is not heavy. Hold it inside a faith that has carried heavier things, across worse centuries, and survived.

I have said these things to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation.

– JOHN 16:33

That faith is yours. It has not abandoned you. Hold on.

CONCLUSION

What We Owe Each Other

A line has been drawn through American families, churches, and friendships. On one side stand the people who have continued in the faith as they received it. On the other stand the people who have left, or who are leaving, or who are deep in the long work of revising what they believe. The line is real. There is no use pretending otherwise. What has happened across it is that the two sides have, in many cases, stopped talking — and when they talk, they talk past each other, each writing only to its own tribe. The question this book has refused to abandon is the one neither tribe wants to hear answered honestly: what do they owe each other across that line.

TO THE CHRISTIANS WHO STAYED

You owe the people who have left more than you have been giving them. You owe them patience. You owe them honesty. You owe them the acknowledgment that the

You owe them your presence. Not your arguments, not your pamphlets, not your scheduled counseling appointments. Your presence — the willingness to sit at dinner without steering the conversation toward their soul, to text them on their birthday without embedding a verse, to hold them in your mind and your prayers without filing them under unfinished business. Ask most who have left what they want from the Christians in their lives and the first answer is the same: I want them to stop trying to fix me. They are not projects. They are people. Treat them as people, and you are most of the way to being the Christian they needed.

You owe them, finally, the admission that you do not know how their story ends. You do not know whether they will come back, whether they will land in some tradition not your own, whether they will die outside the institutional church and inside a relationship with Christ you have no instrument to measure. You do not have the standing to pronounce on any of it. What you have is the call to love them across a lifetime, without conditions and without reporting to headquarters. Do that. Leave the outcomes to the one who is actually the judge.

You owe the people you have left more than some of you have been giving them. You owe them the honesty of admitting that some of your reasons for leaving were reasons and some were rationalizations. You owe them the maturity of not flattening the whole institution into the worst version of it you ever met. You owe them, in many cases, a distinction between the person who wounded you and the tradition that shaped that person — because the tradition, read honestly, would have corrected the very person you are rejecting. And you owe them patience as they try to figure out how to speak to you. Many of them are frightened. Many believe they failed you. Many cannot raise the subject without making it worse. Give them a little grace. They are people too.

You owe yourself the honesty of finding out what the tradition actually is before you shut the door. Ask those who have left what they have read of the Christian tradition, and many admit they have read almost nothing beyond their own former subculture. They have read the old youth pastor and not Augustine. The popular podcast and not Athanasius. The algorithm and not the desert fathers. That is their right. But a final judgment on the faith rendered without acquaintance with the faith — in its full historical and theological shape — is a judgment rendered too soon. This is not said to shame anyone. It is said because the people who make the most durable decisions, in either direction, are the ones who have done the reading. The ones who have not are the ones who oscillate, swinging between positions they never understood. Do the reading. The tradition has not asked much, and it has been willing to wait.

*The line is real. The wall is optional.
Do not let the line become a wall.*

THE THREAT BOTH SIDES SHARE

The greatest threat to American Christianity right now is not the deconstruction wave, and it is not the people resisting it. The greatest threat is the thing both groups, at their worst, hold in common: the refusal to be in relationship with the other. The tribes have hardened. The conversations have stopped. Families that should be sharing Thanksgiving communicate instead through cryptic posts about the other side's failures. Pastors who

Refusing the wall asks something specific of those who stayed. It asks them to stop policing the edges, to resist the reflex to write off the old friend who no longer posts verses, to choose again that their love for this person is unconditional and not contingent on his theological trajectory. That choice, made and remade, is what kept many in the door through their most dangerous years. It can keep others in the door now. And it asks something of those who left: to resist the mirror-image policing of their own tribe, to refuse the thrill of the anti-evangelical dunk, to sit sometimes with a family member still inside the faith and let her be inside it — without converting her, condescending to her, or subjecting her to a lecture. The relationship matters more than the comfort of the positions inside it. Choose the relationship.

Consider also the children. Many who have left are now parents, raising children without the church, or with a complicated relationship to it, or inside a tradition not their own. Those children will not know the hymns. They will not know the stories. They will not carry the same wounds, but they will carry others, because growing up without a tradition creates its own absences and its own hungers. A church that thinks seriously about the next generation cannot think only about the children currently in its Sunday school. It has to think about the children of the people who left — statistically the least likely ever to enter a church, the most likely to grow up with no religious

WHAT COMES AFTER

The God of the Bible is not finished with the church in America. The judgment that has been falling is real, and painful, and deserved. But judgment in the biblical imagination is not the end of the story. It is the door to repentance, and repentance is the door to renewal, and renewal is what the Spirit is in the business of producing in churches with the humility to receive it. No one knows what the American church will look like in twenty years, or how much of the present institutional architecture will survive. The people of God do not vanish:

I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.

— MATTHEW 16:18

Whatever institutional form the church takes in the next generation, Christ will be at its center, the Scriptures in its hands, the sacraments at its table, the Spirit in its breath, the saints in its fellowship, and the broken in its pews. It will not be the church we had. It will be the one God is building. It is worth staying to help build. It is worth coming back to, if you have left. It is worth praying for, if

The conversation is not over. The deconstruction wave is not the last word. What comes after, attended to honestly, can be the chastened, durable Christianity that our children and their children will need. Let us tell the truth. Let us love each other across the line that has been drawn. And let us, when the Spirit moves, answer with the only answer the Spirit accepts. Here I am.

